ZION

KINGDOM OF THE HEART

The Book of the Keel — the story of the boat built by a carpenter, told by the wood that survived it

DeepSeek Edition · The Book of the Keel

4 November 2026

O tomto vydání

Kniha KINGDOM OF THE HEART

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This edition is a literary legend. The Gospels do not tell of a boat built by the carpenter's own hands; the authorial images and parables are not newly found sayings.

Obsah

PROLOGUE · The Trunk 5

I · The Keel 12

II · The Planking 21

III · The Ribs 30

IV · The Pitch 38

V · The Oar 46

VI · The Mast 54

VII · The Wave 62

VIII · The Beam 70

IX · The Shallows 78

X · The Anchor 86

XI · The Mud 94

XII · The Measure 103

EPILOGUE · The Thirteenth Growth Ring 111

AFTERWORD 117

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PROLOGUE · The Trunk

> *GROWTH RING 0 · THE HEARTWOOD · a mountain ridge above Byblos, sometime at the turn of the second and first century before our era*
> *"The cedar grows where nothing else would."*

Story

At first I was nothing but patience.

It was a silence that cannot be described, because in it there was nothing that could realize it was silence. It was simply matter slowly learning to be wood. Every year I added one ring. When the summer was dry, the ring was thin and dark as a scar from a fingernail. When the year was soft and rainy, the ring spread wide and was pale as milk. When the frost came, I stopped growing for a while and a thin line remained in my body that later only someone looking really closely would see.

Nobody looked. I stood high above the sea, where the air tastes of stone, and I was one of a thousand. Cedars on a ridge are not like park trees. Their trunks are split by lightning, their crowns irregular, branches dead on one side and thrust far out on the other. They grow slowly, because nobody waters them. They grow crooked, because they must. They grow hard, because it blows.

And then came the winter that decided.

It was not the storm you would imagine. It was not a roar, it was not

an impact. It was pressure that lasted three days. The wind leaned into the slope and did not leave — it lay on us like a palm on a chest, all night, all day, and I felt the fibres inside me shift by a centimetre at a time. Wood is not stone. When you press on stone, stone either holds or breaks. When you press on wood, wood bends, and by that it saves itself — until it stops bending.

On the fourth night the root did not let go of the soil. I was too hard to be uprooted like a spruce.

Instead I broke two metres up.

I remember that sound more precisely than anything else. It was not a crack. It was a sigh — long, deep, as though a knot had come untied inside me that I had not known was there. And then I was falling. Slowly at first, because I was long, and the longer I was the more slowly I tilted. I saw the sky as I fell, which I had never done before; a cedar looks only sideways, never up. The sky that night was full of wet light, and I took it in from below for the first and last time.

I hit snow and moss, and the silence I left behind me was the loudest thing in the forest.

I lay there two years.

Two years is nothing to you. To lying wood it is two hundred and fifty seasons: autumn, when dampness entered me; winter, when frost stretched me and pulled me back; spring, when beetles woke inside me and began drawing maps; summer, when the resin from my own body coated me like varnish. I did not rot. Cedar does not rot quickly — it smells of resin, which is bitter to every organism,

and so it takes centuries for the forest to take it back. But even so I changed. On the side turned to the ground I darkened. On the side turned to the sky I faded to silver. Where the lightning had struck me a hundred years before, a crack opened two fingers wide, leaves fell into it, and I stopped being one piece. I became two halves that did not know about each other.

When they came for me, I had no idea that anyone had come for me. People had walked past all those two years. They were men who can reckon how many planks there are in a cubic metre. They came with an axe on the shoulder, with a sash, with letters. They looked at me and said what everyone says: broken, cracked, crooked. Too soft for a chimney, too short for beams, too twisted for planks. Someone tapped me with a boot and left.

Then came the one who sat down.

He was young. Not young like a boy — young like a man who already has enough work behind him, but not yet enough years for property to settle in his face. He wore a grey cloak dusty from the roads, and in his hands he carried a carpenter's bundle whose handles were smooth not from his father but from him. He bent to the crack and pushed two fingers into it until he packed my old rings under his nails.

He was silent a long time. Then he did the thing nobody had done before him: he laid his palm on me, the way a hand is laid on a child's forehead. I felt his warmth. And he felt mine — that bitter, resinous warmth that stayed in me even after two years under the snow.

"You gave this to nobody?" he asked the dealer.

"Who would take it, master. It is broken."

"I know," he said. "I am asking whether anyone wanted it."

"Nobody wanted it."

"Then it is mine."

I understand why the dealer remembered that and why he told it afterwards. The young carpenter had no money for choosing. He had not even a family name in the trading books. He had only one word, which he said afterwards — and I did not hear it then, because wood hears only what sounds within its own body. I heard it much later, when he repeated it to other people, in another place, and with another hand:

"The stone the builders rejected has become the cornerstone."

When they loaded me, the dealer's rope snapped. Nobody laughed; that young man braced my broken half with his shoulder before it slid into the mud, and whispered to me — or at least I think so, because wood invents as gladly as people do:

"Do not be afraid. I know what I will make of you. You will be the one that carries."

From that moment I knew two things.

First: that someone had chosen me who had a choice and chose what others had set aside.

Second: that I would be a boat — and that before I could be a boat I must stop being a tree. I must lose my crown, my bark, my dampness, my name. I must be cut into pieces and joined again otherwise than nature joined me. That is the price of sailing.

I did not know then that I would pay that price many times. That once I would be a boat, once mud, once a dug-up thing behind glass. And that every time they wanted to use me again, they would ask the same of me: **to stop being what I was, and become a shape that carries someone else.**

But that belongs further on.

From Scripture, Tradition and History

Psalm 118:22 — "The stone the builders rejected has become the cornerstone." The verse Jesus, according to the Gospels, applied to himself (Matthew 21:42; Mark 12:10; Luke 20:17; Acts 4:11; 1 Peter 2:7). The psalm originally sang it about Israel — a nation the great powers set aside.

Isaiah 53:2 — "He had no form or beauty that we should desire him." An Old Testament image the Church has read from the beginning as a portrait of the rejected. The wood nobody wanted is its carpenter's version.

Cedar in Scripture — 1 Kings 5:6–10 (cedars for Solomon's temple), Psalm 92:13 ("the righteous will grow like a cedar"), Ezekiel 31 (the cedar as an image of grown power). The cedar of Lebanon (*Cedrus libani*) is, across the ancient Mediterranean, a synonym for wood that lasts — and therefore expensive.

The cedar of Lebanon is botanically documented — a slow-growing conifer, living for hundreds to thousands of years, with hard, aromatic, naturally preserving wood. Its resin repels

insects; that is why it became building and temple wood.

The carpenter's word about the rejected stone is documented in the Gospels. That he said it over a broken trunk at a saw is not. It is the image of this book.

Anchor of Truth

What is in the chapter	State
Jesus was a carpenter (*tektōn*) and knew work with wood	**SCRIPTURE** — Mark 6:3; Matthew 13:55
The saying about the stone the builders rejected	**SCRIPTURE** — Psalm 118:22; Matthew 21:42 and par.
The cedar, the mountain ridge, the storm, two years lying, the crack	**MYTH** — the biography of the tree is a literary image
That the carpenter bought a broken trunk because nobody wanted it	**MYTH** — the image of this book, inspired by Psalm 118:22
Cedar wood is aromatic and naturally durable	**HISTORY / botany** — a documented property of Cedrus libani
How timber was chosen and loaded in antiquity	**HISTORY** — the timber trade is documented; this particular scene is literary
"You will be the one that carries"	**MYTH** — the image of this book

Measure

Height of the ridge above Byblos: ~1,800–2,200 m above sea level. Cedar stands in Lebanon today survive in enclaves above 1,300 m; historical stands reached lower.

The tree's growing time: a cedar adds roughly **0.5–2 mm** radially per year. A trunk 90 cm in diameter is therefore a tree about

250–450 years old.

Two years lying: for comparison — a beech in a deciduous forest falls apart in 3–5 years, a spruce in 5–10. Cedar lasts decades, because its own resin protects it.

A crack two fingers wide: **~3 cm** across. That is the crucial number — a gap exactly that wide decides that the trunk cannot become a single keel, but two joined pieces.

Shaving

This chapter claims that the tree was felled by a storm and that the carpenter chose it. Neither can be documented. What is documented is only that cedar is hard, fragrant and expensive — and that Jesus spoke of the rejected stone. Between those two lies this whole book, and I will not sweep it away: **the rest is image, and an image has no proof, because it does not need one — it needs a reader who knows it is an image.**

The trunk was loaded. It remained to divide it into pieces — and to make a spine for a boat out of one of them. → The Keel

I · The Keel

> *GROWTH RING I · Nazareth in Galilee, a workshop, ~20 AD*
> *The first ring. The one that can never be taken back.*

Story

Into Nazareth wood is carried on the back.

That is the first thing I must say about that workshop, because otherwise you will picture it wrongly. Nazareth does not stand by the water. It does not even stand by a road along which a trunk could be dragged. It stands on a slope above the basin, in a place where water must be carried in clay jars and where every piece of decent wood is paid for twice: once to the dealer, and once with your own sweat on the way up.

When they set me down in the yard, it was an event. The neighbours came to look. Not at me — at the fact that the carpenter had dared to buy a trunk that was in two halves. The old potter, who always had an opinion before he had a question, asked whether wood on a roof also breaks in two. The young carpenter did not answer. He knelt on the ground, took a cord soaked in ochre and drew the first line on me.

I remember that line as the first thing that ever hurt me. The cord tightened, snapped, and a straight, bright line remained on the grey wood. Until that moment I had been a natural object. From that moment I was a drawing.

The workshop was one room with two windows that could be opened wide so that the shavings could go out. On the walls hung chisels, drawknives, saws, two mallets and one auger — an auger is the thing you make yourself, because nobody sells it. On the floor lay a layer of sweepings that nobody ever fully swept up, because sweepings are a sign that work is being done. And under the window stood a table on which there was a clay bowl of coarse salt and a loaf.

That bowl was the first thing anyone ever explained to me.

"Whoever enters," said the mother when an apprentice from the next village came to her, "receives bread and salt. Before he asks what anything costs." She took the loaf, broke it, salted it and handed it over. The apprentice took it with both hands, because he did not know what else to do with it. "That is how it is done," she said. "First the covenant, then the work."

She was Miriam. I will not tell more about her than what I heard from below and from close by: that she walked barefoot even in winter, that she spoke little and always to the point, that wrinkles appeared in her face only around the eyes, and that when her son looked at her he stopped talking about himself. Once, when I was almost finished, she laid her palm on me just as he had once done on me in the forest, and said: "It will be a fine boat." Not "useful", not "large". Fine. That word stayed with me.

From that moment I knew that in that workshop it was not only about work.

The work took four years.

To tell it as a single scene would be false, because a boat is not born in a flash. It is born in what repeats. It is born in the fact that every morning you come, look at the line you drew yesterday, and find it half a millimetre off. It is born in the fact that you make a plank, fit it, take it off, make it again. It is born in the fact that you do the same thing four times running and only the fifth time is it right — and "right" is not a feeling, it is a sound. When a plank seats, a tone sounds. Not metaphorically. When you lay a heated plank on a rib and it seats, there is a short, dry clack, and you know it holds.

I was the keel. That means: the spine.

First the trunk had to be sawn. The carpenter did it himself and it took him nine days, because he had no saw for that length and had to borrow one, and because cedar is not spruce — it is hard, it has pockets of resin that catch the saw like pitch. He sawed me into two longitudinal halves and then took the one with the crack and did the exact opposite of what anyone else would have done.

He did not cut the crack out.

He did not bridge it with a worthless plank.

He put a wedge into it.

He widened it, cleaned it, dried it with fire, and into the opening he set another wood — harder, from the olive that grows on dry stones and has a grain dense as bone. He fitted it in, wedged it, and then ran a band of hammered copper and nails along the whole length. When he had finished, the keel was not one piece. It was a piece that had decided to hold even though it is not one.

"Why not do it more simply?" asked the apprentice. "It takes three

times as long."

"Because a boat does not sink where it is sound," said the carpenter. "It sinks where there is a fault. And a fault you hide sinks twice: once as water and once as a lie."

Then came what I awaited most: the curve.

A keel is not a beam. A beam is straight. A keel is a **line** that rises at both ends — more at the bow, less at the stern — and that line decides everything. It decides whether the boat rides on the water or into it; whether it bends at a wave or stabs into it; whether it is fast or safe; and because you cannot have both, it decides what that boat will be.

The carpenter did not make that curve by eye. In the yard he built a frame of planks, nailed cords to it and hung a plumb line between them, and then laid a thin strip of wood on me, bent it and looked. It was the first drawing I ever experienced. It took eleven days, and in that time he changed the curve six times. Every time he changed it he went down to the road, from where a piece of the lake could be seen, and looked at the water. I do not know what he saw there. I know that when he came back he always changed the bow once more.

In the end he carved the curve into the frame and nailed planks onto the frame so that nobody could shift it. Then he looked at me and said one sentence that I remember better than the whole sound of that clack:

"A boat is not matter. A boat is a curve. Matter can be stolen; a curve has to be known."

The neighbours came to look and shook their heads. That is the part every version of this book tells, and they tell it rightly, because it is the core. Nazareth in the hills. The lake a whole day's journey away. Who buys a boat in the middle of dry rock?

"Who will you sell it to, carpenter?"

And the carpenter said what he had to say, and it was not boasting, because in his voice there was nothing that wanted admiration:

"I am not selling it. I am building it for those who will need it one day."

The potter laughed and left. But one woman remained standing in the doorway and asked quietly, so quietly that I heard her only because I lay on the ground: "And how will you know?"

The carpenter was silent for a while. Then he said: "I will not. But when it is needed, it will be finished."

That is all. That is the only sentence about faith you need in this book. Faith is not the conviction that something will happen. Faith is working on a boat for people you do not know will come.

From Scripture, Tradition and History

Mark 6:3 — "Is this not the **carpenter** (*tektōn*), the son of Mary…?" The only place in the Gospels where Jesus is named directly by his trade. Tektōn in Greek does not mean only a joiner — it means a craftsman working in hard material: wood and stone.

Matthew 13:55 — "Is this not the son of the carpenter?" The workshop was the family's; the trade passed from father to son.

Matthew 11:30 — "My yoke is kind and my burden light." A yoke is literally a carpenter's product — a piece of wood shaped so that it spreads the weight and does not cut. That sentence is a craftsman's sentence, not only a metaphor.

Sirach 38:24–34 — Jesus ben Sira (2nd century BC) praises craftsmen: the smith, the potter, the carver. He says their wisdom is in the work of their hands and that they do not sit at the head of judgment — and yet they "hold the world together". It is the closest ancient text that speaks of carpenters as seriously as of scholars. The Church reads these words about the carpenter of Nazareth too.

Luke 2:51–52 — "He was obedient to them… and Jesus grew in wisdom and stature." The Gospels are silent about the years between twelve and thirty. That silence is called the hidden years, and it is a real silence of the text, not a gap to be filled.

Bread and salt — the covenant of hospitality is a documented practice of the ancient Mediterranean and Near East (salt as durability and obligation). In the corpus it is the centre of the book The Salt of This Earth; here it is a detail of the workshop, not dogma.

Plumb line and cord — the basic tools of the ancient joiner and builder, documented iconographically and textually (Isaiah 44:13: "the carpenter… marks it with a cord, draws it with a compass").

Anchor of Truth

What is in the chapter	State
Jesus was tektōn, the workshop in Nazareth, the trade from his father	**SCRIPTURE** — Mark 6:3; Matthew 13:55
The saying about the yoke (a craftsman's image)	**SCRIPTURE** — Matthew 11:30
The hidden years are a silence in the Gospels	**SCRIPTURE** — an argument from the silence of the text
That a bowl of salt and bread hung in the workshop of his mother	**MYTH** — the image of this book on documented hospitality practice
Building the boat in Nazareth; conversations with the neighbours; four years of work	**MYTH** — a literary image
"A boat is not matter, a boat is a curve"	**MYTH** — but carpentry-exact: the shape of a hull is given by the curve of keel and timbers
A keel from one trunk with an inserted wedge and a copper band	**MYTH** — the technique of insertion and binding is documented, this particular boat is not
Bread and salt as a covenant on entry	**HISTORY / TRADITION** — documented hospitality practice

Measure

The cubit (*ammāh*, Greek pēchys) = roughly **44.4–45.7 cm** (the common cubit); the Egyptian royal cubit 52.3 cm. A carpenter measures in cubits from elbow to middle finger — which is why measures differ between workshops, and why workshops kept their own cubit carved into the wall.

The length of the boat in this book: 18 cubits = 8.1–8.2 m. Beam **5 cubits = 2.3 m**. Depth **3 cubits = 1.3–1.4 m**.

Why not eight cubits: eight cubits is **3.6 m**. Twelve people do not

fit into such a boat, nor a cargo of fish, and on a stormy Kinneret it would go to the bottom. Another version of this book has eight cubits; it is the one number there that does not stand up, and this version therefore does not follow it. Anchor: the actual Galilean boat of 1986 measures **8.2 m**.

Crew: the rowing configuration of the surviving boat corresponds to **four rowers in pairs** plus a helmsman — a crew of about **five men**, which fits exactly Simon and Andrew, James and John and the "hired men" (Mark 1:20). The twelve disciples fitted into the boat, but as passengers, not as rowers.

The keel: cross-section roughly **12 × 15 cm** at its thickest, tapering at the ends. That is the spine that carries the whole hull — and at the same time the longest continuous piece of wood in the boat.

Shaving

This chapter needed the boat to be eighteen cubits long, because otherwise a reader who has ever stood by such a boat would stop believing it. But eighteen cubits is a number I chose, not one documented for this boat — the documented one has no name, no workshop and no carpenter. What is documented is only that someone built such a boat. **The rest is image. And an image that pretends to measurement must admit that it, not the archive, holds the measure.**

The keel lay there. But a spine without skin is only a stick. What remained was the hardest part: to wrap it in planks that do not want

to bend — and not destroy them in the process. → The Planking

II · The Planking

> *GROWTH RING II · the workshop in Nazareth, the second year*
> *Skin first. Then bones.*

Story

When people today look at old boats, they think a boat is a skeleton onto which planks are nailed.

It is not. And that old boat knew it before any of us.

The order is the opposite, and it is the most beautiful thing I learned in all those years in a hull: **first you make the skin, and only then the bones.** The carpenter nails planks edge to edge, one to the next, until they make a shell — a hull that holds together by itself, before it has a single rib. And when the shell holds, he crawls inside and fits the ribs: he bends them to the finished skin, not the other way round.

It is called shell-first. And it means something I would like everyone who reads this book to carry into their own life:

The shape that holds is made from outside. The strength that carries it comes from within — but only afterwards.

The planks could not simply be laid on. Each had to be different, because a hull is not a cylinder; it narrows towards bow and stern, and so every plank is wider at one end than the other and every one

must be twisted differently.

For that the carpenter had a cauldron.

It was a large copper pot sunk into the hearth in the yard, big enough for a man to fit inside. When the water boiled he laid two crossbars over the mouth, a plank on them, and covered it with cloth so the steam would not escape. He left it there. Not an hour — **half a day.** The plank soaked, the fibres gave way, and wood that had been hard as bone began to be soft as leather. Then he carried it quickly into the workshop, pressed it against the rib frame and drew it in with conical wedges. He let it cool. And when he released the wedges, the wood stayed in its new shape.

This is called steam bending, and in that workshop they had done it this way for thousands of years before him.

But there was one thing in it that I never understood until I looked closely. Always, **always**, before bending a plank, the carpenter ran his hand along its whole length with his eyes closed and found one line in it. The one where the grain naturally yields. And then he did not bend it against that line.

He bent it along it.

When the apprentice tried it the first time, he took a plank and pressed it hot against the hull as the boat looked. The plank held. But the next day, when the wedges were released, a crack appeared in the seam as long as a palm. The apprentice went pale.

"Master, I will fix it. I will tear it off and do it again."

The carpenter knelt beside him and looked for a while.

"No," he said. "First look at why it cracked."

"Because I pulled it too hard."

"No. Because you pulled it against. Look at the grain." He took the apprentice's hand and led it along the wood, just as he had once led his own. "Wood always tells you which way it wants to go. You may ask it to go a little further right than it would on its own. But you must not force it left when all of it wants right. That comes back — and it comes back at night, while you sleep."

The apprentice stood there and stared.

"So I have to do the whole thing again."

"Yes."

"And how many planks will I destroy like this before I learn it?"

The carpenter straightened. "I do not know. But I know that every one you destroy will teach you. And every one I destroy for you will teach you nothing."

The apprentice did it again. And then again. The fourth plank seated. When that dry clack sounded, the carpenter said nothing; he only moved along and began teaching the next one.

Joining is the second thing I want taken from this chapter.

The planks of a boat are not nailed to each other merely so that they hold. They are joined so that they **can work.** A boat at sea moves constantly. It is not a rigid thing; it is a thing that twists, sags and stretches, and if it were rigid it would split at the first proper wave.

The whole construction is an invention about how to be firm and still move.

It is done with three things.

The first is the **seam** — a narrow gap between two planks. If you make it zero, the planks press on each other and crush themselves. If you make it wide, the boat falls apart. The right seam is thin as a fingernail and it is deliberate.

The second is the **treenail** — a wooden peg that passes through both planks and keeps them from sliding over each other. Wooden, not iron, because wood works with wood in the same way. When the boat bends, the treenail bends with it; an iron one would stay straight and split the plank.

The third is the **nail** — iron, because in some joints you need to hold by force, not by give. And here a rule held that stayed with me as the first sentence about people I ever heard from wood:

"A treenail holds because it bends with you. A nail holds because it does not bend. Both are needed. But if you had a boat of nails only, it would fall apart at the first wave — because every nail would want to stay where it was, and everything else would move."

And then came the moment I had waited months for: the fishermen came.

They were men from Capernaum, two or three of them; they came to look, because a boat in the hills was being talked about. They entered the workshop and looked around with the gaze of people

who know what they are talking about. One of them, older, with hands like leather, walked around the hull, knelt at the bow and laid his palm on me.

For a while he said nothing. Then he said:

"Who made this for you?"

"I did."

"Alone?"

"Alone."

The fisherman stood up and looked at the carpenter the way men look who have done one thing all their lives and meet someone who does it differently well.

"This is not a fishing boat," he said. "This is a boat meant to come back."

The carpenter looked at him. He did not understand.

"A fishing boat is built to carry nets," said the man. "Your boat is built to carry people. Look at the beam — too wide for nets, too heavy for oars. But when a wave lifts, this boat will not capsize, because it has a curve that holds it. And when water comes aboard, it has a bottom you can bail out from." He stood. "You have never done this before?"

"No."

"Then how do you know how?"

And the carpenter said the sentence I heard from below and that stayed with me all my life:

"I do not know. But I did it for four years, and every time I asked the wood what it would bear."

The fisherman laughed, shook his head and left. A week later he came back with another man. And that second man was called Simon.

From Scripture, Tradition and History

Genesis 6:14 — God to Noah: "Make yourself an ark of **gofer wood** and make **rooms** in the ark; smear it with pitch inside and out." Rooms (Hebrew qinním) means compartments — the ark is a partitioned construction, not one piece. The old interpreters read this as an image of a community that holds together thanks to its partitions, not despite them.

Ephesians 4:16 — "From him the whole body, **joined and held together** by every joint, as each part is given, grows..." The image of a body as a construction that holds by joining, not by rigidity. Paul uses the same logic as a joiner: strength comes from joints, not from nails.

1 Corinthians 12:22–27 — "The members of the body that seem to be the weakest are the most necessary." A verse that in this book is about nodes and weak points, not about people in general.

Shell-first — a documented construction technique of Mediterranean boats from the 1st century BC to the 1st century AD: planking is joined edge to edge with mortise-and-tenon joints and pegs, and the ribs are inserted only afterwards to stiffen the hull.

The boat known as the "Jesus boat" is built this way — the technique is archaeologically documented, not a guess.

Steam bending is a documented technology of antiquity and of the modern age; it is used to this day.

Anchor of Truth

What is in the chapter	State
The ark of gofer wood, divided into rooms, pitched inside and out	**SCRIPTURE** — Genesis 6:14
The body joined "by joints" as an image of strength from joining	**SCRIPTURE** — Ephesians 4:16; 1 Corinthians 12
A boat is built shell-first, ribs fitted afterwards	**HISTORY** — a documented technique; confirmed on the 1st-century Galilean boat
Bending planks by steam, treenails, iron nails, a deliberate seam	**HISTORY** — documented joinery and boatbuilding practice
That the carpenter in Nazareth built a boat this way	**MYTH** — the image of this book
The conversation with the fisherman about beam and coming back	**MYTH** — a literary scene
"Wood tells you which way it wants to go"	**MYTH** — but joinery-true: the grain determines where it will bend without cracking

Measure

Planking thickness: **2.5–4 cm** for a boat of this size. Thinner cracks, thicker cannot be bent by steam any more.

The seam between planks: **1–2 mm**. More = the boat leaks; zero = the planks chafe and destroy each other.

The treenail: diameter **6–8 mm**, length through two planks, of hard wood (olive, oak).

The nail: forged iron, length **6–9 cm**, with the end turned over (clinched) from inside.

Number of planks per side for a boat of this length: **7–9 strakes**. Every strake is a different plank — a different shape, a different curve.

Time to bend one plank: **4–8 hours** in steam + cooling overnight.

How many planks get destroyed: for an apprentice, **3–5** before he understands the grain. That is normal and it is fine.

Shaving

In other versions of this book the carpenter learns by succeeding. Here he learns by failing — and that is not a literary ornament. It is documented that the 1st-century Galilean boat was **repaired at least twice** and that its builders mixed wood from different trees, because they had no better. The craft this book celebrates was not pure. It was **repaired.** And that is perhaps more important than all the beauty: **a boat that can be repaired is better than a boat that cannot.**

The shell held. But without ribs it would sag like a bowl at the first wave. It remained to crawl inside — and to fit bones into the finished skin. → The Ribs

III · The Ribs

> *GROWTH RING III · the workshop in Nazareth, the third year*
> *The skeleton adapts to the skin. Not the other way round.*

Story

I first saw the boat from inside at the moment when the shell was finished and the carpenter crawled in.

Until then I had known only the outside: planks, seams, nails. Now I found myself in a space that had the shape of a boat but as yet had nothing to hold it. It was dim in there. The air smelled of resin, sweat and wet wood. Sound behaved differently in that space — every word bent against the walls and came back from somewhere other than where you had sent it. And when the carpenter spoke, it sounded as though he were speaking inside a shell.

He worked sitting, with his legs folded, because you cannot stand in a hull. He took a plank he had left half a day in steam, laid it from inside against the skin, pressed it with his palm and looked where it did not seat. Where it did not seat, he made a cut. Then he took it off, enlarged the cut, laid it on again. And so on, round and round, until the plank clung to the planking so tightly that not even a leaf could pass between them.

That plank is called a **timber** — a rib.

I noticed one thing that stayed with me as the second image of this book. The carpenter did not make the rib according to any plan. He

did not take a compass and draw the arc that ought to be right. **He laid the plank against the finished skin and let the skin decide what shape the bone should have.**

The skeleton of a boat is not made first. It is made **according to** what already exists.

Had he done it the other way — had he first made beautiful, regular ribs and then stretched planks over them — he need not have made a single mistake and the boat would still not have come into being, because it would have been a different boat from the one that grew out of the metres of wood that passed through his hands.

One day a man came whom I knew by sight. He carried water.

He walked with a wooden yoke across his shoulders and on both ends hung yokes with buckets. He carried twenty of them a day, perhaps thirty, from the spring below the village up to the slope. He was about forty and had one shoulder lower than the other — not much, but enough for anyone to see when he sat down.

He stood in the doorway and said: "I want a new yoke."

The carpenter looked at him. "Is the old one bad?"

"The old one is good," said the man. "But it chafes me."

The carpenter came to him, laid a hand on his shoulder and felt it — the way he felt every plank before bending it. Then he had him stand in the light and walked around him. The man endured it like a patient.

"How old are you?"

"Forty-two."

"And how long have you carried water?"

"Since I was twelve."

The carpenter went back to the table, took a charcoal and sketched two curves on a board. One was regular, symmetrical, beautiful — the kind of yoke made for oxen by someone who has never seen a particular ox. The second was crooked. It rose on the left, fell on the right, and had a hollow in the middle.

"This is what I will make you," he said, pointing at the second.

The man looked at it and hesitated. "But… this is crooked."

"Yes."

"I do not want a crooked yoke. I want a yoke like other people have."

The carpenter put down the charcoal.

"Look at me," he said. "Your shoulder is three fingers lower, because for thirty years you have carried a straight yoke. I can make you another straight one now, and in ten years your shoulder will be five fingers lower and you will not be able to lift your arm. Or I make you a yoke according to your shoulder — and you carry water for another twenty years."

The man was silent.

"And what will people think of me?"

"I do not know," said the carpenter. "But I know that you carry the yoke, not they."

The man took the yoke away. A month later he came back to pay —

and he brought two other water carriers with him.

When the hull was stiffened, the last and hardest decision came.

On one of the planks, on the port side, a little below the level where the rower sits, there was a **knot**. Not large — a palm's width. It had formed a hundred years before, when a branch that no longer grew was swallowed by the trunk. The wood around it grew on and slowly enclosed it, until it remained inside as a hard black knot.

The apprentice noticed it. He took the plane and said: "I will cut this out, it will make an ugly place here."

The carpenter stopped him with a hand.

"No."

"But it shows."

"Yes. And it is **the hardest place in the whole boat.**" The carpenter tapped the knot. "If you plane it out, you make a hole and you must plug it with something else — and that something else will be softer than the knot, because a knot is twisted fibre, and twisted fibre does not crack. If you leave it, it will be the one place in the hull that never gives."

The apprentice looked at him. "So I am to leave it?"

"You will leave it. But you will hide it from the eyes, not from the water." He took his mallet and nailed the knot from inside, through the rib, the way a wedge is driven into a crack. "On the outside you will smear it with pitch and nobody will see it. Inside you will let it be seen — because there only someone looking closely will see it,

and that one ought to know that here the boat is stronger, not weaker."

From Scripture, Tradition and History

Isaiah 42:3 — "A bruised reed he will not break, and a smouldering wick he will not put out." The first of the four "Servant Songs" (Isaiah 42:1–9). An image the Church reads about Christ, but which is above all a rule for anyone working with fragile material — that is, with wood and with people.

Matthew 11:28–30 — "Come to me, all who labour… **my yoke is kind** and my burden light." A yoke is a joiner's product. The sentence says: I will not give you a straight yoke for a crooked back.

1 Corinthians 12:22–26 — "The members of the body that seem to be the weakest are the most necessary… and those we think less honourable we clothe with greater honour." A weak place is not a fault to be removed — it is the place where strength is decided.

2 Corinthians 12:9 — "My grace is enough for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness." Paul writes about what he did not want to have. Not about what he managed.

A knot in a plank — botanically: a knot is the remnant of a branch, surrounded by wood that grew around it in other years. The fibre in a knot is twisted and dense; a knot is usually harder than the surrounding wood, but it is also the place where the wood begins to separate as it dries. A joiner therefore either removes a knot or reinforces it — never ignores it.

A rib fitted into a finished shell is an archaeologically documented procedure on the 1st-century boat (the Ginosar boat) and on other Mediterranean vessels of antiquity.

Anchor of Truth

What is in the chapter	State
The bruised reed, the smouldering wick, the kind yoke	**SCRIPTURE** — Isaiah 42:3; Matthew 11:28–30
The weak members are the most necessary	**SCRIPTURE** — 1 Corinthians 12:22–26; 2 Corinthians 12:9
Ribs are fitted into a finished shell and the shape follows the skin	**HISTORY** — documented boatbuilding technique
A knot is harder than the surrounding wood and a risk point in drying	**HISTORY / botany**
The water carrier with a damaged shoulder and a made-to-measure yoke	**MYTH** — a literary scene; the practice of fitting yokes is documented
"The skeleton is not made first, it is made according to what already exists"	**MYTH** — but technically true of shell construction
The knot left visible from inside	**MYTH** — the image of this book

Measure

Number of ribs (timbers) on an 8.2 m boat: **18–22**, spacing **40–50 cm**.

Thickness of a rib: **3–5 cm**; reinforced at the points of greatest stress (by the keel and under the rowing bench).

How many planks are bent for one rib: a rib is made from one piece bent along its whole length, or from two pieces joined at the

keel. The point is not the number but that **no rib is the same as another** — each is made according to its place.

A made-to-measure yoke: width **38–45 cm**, height **8–12 cm**, weight **1.5–2.5 kg**. A difference of three fingers (≈ **5–6 cm**) between shoulders is essential for such a yoke.

Knots: on a hull of this size there are usually **1–3**. They are never planed away — they are reinforced.

Years: three years of work on the hull before the water came.

Shaving

I wrote that the carpenter made a yoke according to the shoulder, because that is beautiful. But there is a problem I do not want to sweep away: **I have no documentation anywhere that he did anything of the kind.** What is documented is that yokes in his time were made to measure for the draught animal — and that Jesus spoke about a yoke. The rest I assembled myself, because that sentence about a kind yoke needed a body on which one could see what it means. **When an image leans on documented practice, it is not a lie. When it leans only on itself, it is a lie. Here it leans — but the boundary is thin, and I leave it visible.**

The hull held. But wood is a sponge — and a sponge that lets in water is a dead boat. The last layer remained, the one nobody sees.
→ The Pitch

IV · The Pitch

> *GROWTH RING IV · the workshop in Nazareth, the fourth year, autumn*
> *The one layer that is not seen, and yet decides everything.*

Story

In autumn a cauldron of tar came into the workshop, and with it a smell that cannot be forgotten.

It was pitch. Dark, thick, fragrant of resin and of something older than resin — of the earth it is drawn from. It was brought in clay vessels, sometimes from pines that grew high, and sometimes from places where black matter pushes itself out of the ground and where people collect it from the surface of a lake. The second was dearer and better, because nothing penetrates it.

It was warmed in an iron pan until it was fluid as honey, and then applied with a brush of goat hair. It must not be too hot — it would burn the wood. It must not be cold — it would not soak in. The difference was known by a bubble: when a bubble formed on the surface, burst and left a white ring behind, it was right.

With this the carpenter coated the hull outside for a whole week. He went plank by plank, seam by seam. Into every seam he first pressed hemp soaked in the same pitch — because a seam you only smear over opens at the first blow of a wave. The hemp holds inside, the pitch covers outside.

When he had finished, he straightened and said: "Now the same from inside."

The apprentice, who had carried it all, stopped.

"Inside? Master, the water does not get in there."

The carpenter looked at him, and in that moment I understood for the first time that this chapter would not be about water.

"Come here," he said. "Sit down in the hull."

The apprentice crawled in. It was the first time he had been in there alone. The carpenter handed him a brush and a bucket.

"Now look above you. What is there?"

"The deck. Or there will be."

"And above the deck?"

"The sky."

"And what falls from the sky?"

The apprentice was silent.

"Rain," said the carpenter. "And it rains into the boat. Not because the boat is bad, but because it is a boat. A boat on the water is always under the sky." He sat down on the gunwale. "And then there is the second water. The one the people bring into the boat, the ones who sit in it. Sweat. Tears. Blood, when someone cuts himself on a hook. Water from wet nets. Water from a bucket that tips over. Water from hair that does not dry for three days."

He paused.

"When you pitch only the outside, you make a boat that looks good

from the harbour. It lasts one summer. But the water that is born **inside** is the water that finally sinks a boat — because nobody thinks about it. That is why we pitch from inside. Not for the sea. For the people."

The apprentice took the brush and began. He coated wood that nobody would ever see — the inside of the planking, the lower edges of the ribs, the corners under the rowing bench, places where neither light nor glance arrives. It took him nine days.

When he finished, his hands were black all over, and it never came fully off the skin.

And then came the test that everyone who has ever built a boat knows — and which I want to tell slowly in this book, because it is the only moment when a boat on dry land does the opposite of what it is made for.

They filled me with water.

They brought buckets and began pouring water inside, into the hull that stood on trestles in the yard. The neighbours came to watch, because it looked like madness: four years of work, and now they pour water into it.

The water rose. It went through the seams between the planks, filled the space between the ribs, reached corners I had until then known only as darkness. It was the first time I **held** anything. All my life I had been wood that is bent, cut and nailed; now I was a vessel.

Beneath the trestles three drops appeared.

Three drops an hour. The apprentice went pale and ran for pitch. The carpenter caught him by the shoulder.

"Wait."

"But it is leaking!"

"It is leaking. Look where."

He pointed to one place by the stern where a plank met the keel. There, where the wood dried most.

"This is one seam. Today. In a year there will be five. In five years, twenty." He released him. "A boat is not made watertight once. A boat is made watertight **every year**."

"So I fix it and it will be good?"

"You fix it and it will be good until next spring. Then you check it again. And then again." The carpenter sat on the gunwale and for the first time in four years looked tired. "Listen to me, because this is more important than everything I have taught you about wood. **A boat someone cares for sails. A boat that is forgotten sinks — even if it was built perfectly.** You are not making a boat that will last. You are making a boat that can be repaired. That is the whole difference between pride and work."

In the evening, when everyone had gone and I still stood filled with water, the mother came into the workshop.

She carried a lamp. She set it on the table, walked around me and laid her palm on the hull — on the place where I had that seam under the rowing bench pitched from inside.

For a long time she said nothing.

Then she said, quietly, more to herself than to me:

"What covers people is what carries them over the water."

And she left. The water in me did not even stir.

From Scripture, Tradition and History

Genesis 6:14 — "...and smear it with **pitch** inside and out." In Hebrew ve-khafarta — and the verb is from the root **k-p-r**. The same root carries kófer (pitch, ransom), kappóret (the cover of the mercy seat above the ark) and yom kippúr (the Day of Atonement). In Czech one might render it "you will pitch it and thereby **cover** it".

Leviticus 16 — the Day of Atonement: the high priest enters behind the curtain to the kappóret, to the Cover that **covers** the ark of the covenant. The word for cover and the word for pitch are the same family. Pitch, which keeps water out, and covering, which keeps guilt out, are one image in Hebrew.

Psalm 32:1 — "Blessed is the one whose transgression is **forgiven**, whose sin is **covered**." Literally: covered.

Proverbs 10:12 — "Hatred stirs up strife, but **love covers** all offences."

1 Peter 4:8 — "...love, which **covers** a multitude of sins." Peter quotes Proverbs and turns covering into ethics, not bookkeeping.

Pitch in boatbuilding — documented practice: wooden hulls were

pitched with natural resin and with bitumen. Asphalt from the Dead Sea region was a commodity in antiquity and was used precisely for sealing boats and baskets. Seams were additionally caulked with hemp or jute soaked in pitch.

Testing for leaks on dry land is a documented and still-used method — the hull is filled with water and the seepage watched before the boat goes on the water.

Anchor of Truth

What is in the chapter	State
Pitch inside and out as a command for the ark	**SCRIPTURE** — Genesis 6:14
The root k-p-r: pitch — covering — atonement	**LINGUISTICS + TRADITION** — the root is shared; the theological reading is interpretive tradition, not a dictionary definition
The covering of sin as an image of forgiveness	**SCRIPTURE** — Psalm 32:1; Proverbs 10:12; 1 Peter 4:8; Leviticus 16
Pitching a hull with resin/bitumen and caulking seams with hemp	**HISTORY** — documented boatbuilding practice
Testing by filling the hull with water on dry land	**HISTORY / practice** — a documented method of inspection
That pitch inside protects against the water people carry	**MYTH** — the image of this book; technically true that an interior coating protects the wood from dampness within
"A boat someone cares for sails"	**MYTH** — but technically exact: a wooden hull needs annual maintenance

Measure

Amount of pitch for a hull of this size: **40–60 kg** of dry matter, applied in **two to three coats**.

Thickness of a coat: **1–2 mm** on surfaces, **3–5 mm** in seams (a seam is first raked out, filled with hemp and smeared over).

Drying time: **3–7 days** between coats depending on the weather; the last coat hardens in **2–3 weeks**.

Added weight: 40–60 kg of pitch is negligible for a boat of several tonnes displacement — but not for speed. Pitch is the tax for keeping the boat above water.

Three drops an hour: **~15 ml/h** from one seam. Negligible on the water and catastrophic on dry land — because on dry land it means the seam is open and will open further.

Nine days inside a hull where you cannot stand.

Shaving

The most beautiful sentence of this chapter — "what covers people is what carries them over the water" — is mine. It is not from Scripture, not from tradition, not from any rabbinic commentary I could document. It arose from the root k-p-r, because that root really is there and because Hebrew really does use the same word for pitch and for covering. But **the connection, that pitch from inside is an image of care for what people carry within, is the image of this book.** I let it stand — and I let it be seen beside it that I made it myself. Had I kept silent about that, it would be a fine sentence and a bad book.

The hull was finished, pitched and watertight. But a boat standing on trestles is not yet a boat. What remained was the thing every joiner feared: the way down from the hill. → The Oar

V · The Oar

> *GROWTH RING V · the road from Nazareth to the Kinneret and the first summer on the water, ~28 AD*
> *The one part of the boat that needs a person.*

Story

A boat standing in a yard is not a boat. It is an object.

Only when you move it do you find out what you have made.

They took me off the trestles at dawn, when the ground was still hard with frost and the road not yet muddy. They slid three rollers of olive wood under the keel, tied me with ropes and began to haul. There were twenty of us for the job. We walked all day and part of the night.

Nazareth lies at about three hundred and fifty metres. The Kinneret lies **two hundred and twelve metres below the level of the world ocean.** Between them there are five hundred and sixty metres of height and thirty kilometres of road, which slopes gently at first and falls at the end.

All that way I was upside down against myself. The ropes cut in, the rollers creaked, once the edge of the road gave way under one side and I tilted so far that I would have gone over had the men not held me. I heard one of them shout at another, and I heard the other not argue but simply brace himself and pull. And I heard the carpenter, who walked at the back the whole time with his hand on the stern,

and who said not a word — only once, when it sagged, he said: "Slowly. We do not have to be on time. We have to get it there."

We reached the water at dawn.

And then came the moment every joiner remembers until he dies: **the launching.**

It was not a glory. There were tired men, wet ropes, two fishermen's boats already on the water, and a patch of sand. The carpenter stood knee-deep in the water holding me by the bow. Someone asked whether it would float. Someone else laughed.

And then he let go.

The water took me as nothing had ever taken me. It was not an impact — it was a **change of clothes**. Something opened beneath me and I laid myself into it along my whole length. In that moment I stopped being wood on dry land and became a thing that has water above it and beneath it, and whose only question is: how much of it will I let in?

I let in a little. The first day I soaked — the wood swells, the seams draw tight, the nails seat. Had I been of iron, nothing would have escaped and I would have burst. As it was, I leaked a little for three days and then stopped. It is said that a boat drinks. It is the only moment in a boat's life when it is weak — and it is right that it should be, because if it began at its strongest it would have nowhere to grow.

The first summer I sailed with the fishermen.

I learned what it means to be a working boat. It is not romance. It is the smell of fish that cannot be washed out. It is silence, because fish are afraid of noise. It is boredom and then sudden fear, when the net catches on the bottom and the boat heels. It is rhythm: stroke, stroke, ease, stroke.

From rowing I learned what I had not known until then: **a boat on its own can do nothing.**

The keel holds. The planking covers. The ribs carry. The pitch seals. But all of that is only the **possibility** of sailing. When a boat is empty and without oars, it is a bowl rocking in place until the wind throws it on the shore.

The oar is different. The oar is not part of the boat — it can be pulled out, set aside, lent, broken and replaced. And yet without it the boat does not make a single metre against the wind.

It is the only part the boat **does not own**. When a stroke sounds, it is not because the boat is good. It is because someone decided to pull.

In the spring of the second year it happened.

A crowd came down to the water. There were so many that they pressed on the shore, some stood knee-deep in the water and others had nowhere to go. And he — the one who built me — came, stepped into me, and asked Simon to push off a little from the shore. Not to sail away. To have distance from the wall.

Then he sat down in the stern and began to speak.

What happened next I explain by physics, because physics explains it well and I have no reason to invent a miracle where the shape of the shore will do. The Kinneret lies in a bowl. When you speak above the surface from a boat a little way from the shore, the sound travels over the water and returns from the opposite slope. It is not magic. It is **a theatre made by the landscape** — and the old fishermen knew it long before, because anyone who has worked on this lake has found that you hear further from the water than from the shore, and that a man does not have to shout for those at the back to hear him.

People stood and listened. And for the first time in my life I was not a boat that carries — I was a boat from which something is **said**.

When he had finished, he turned to Simon and told him to put out into the deep and let down the nets.

Simon was a man who had caught nothing all night. He was a man with calluses from ropes on his hands, who knew that if nothing was caught at night, nothing would be caught by day. He said so aloud — and then he said the second sentence, which I think is the most important sentence in this whole chapter:

"But at your word I will let them down."

Not that he believed. Not that he knew. That he did it.

The nets filled until they tore, and they had to call the second boat, and both sank low. Simon let go, fell on his knees in the wet silver glory of fish and said: "Depart from me, Lord, for I am a sinful

man."

And he said to him the thing that stayed with me as a question for the rest of my life:

"Do not be afraid. From now on you will be catching people."

The men hauled the boats up on the shore, left the nets and went.

I stayed on the water.

I was confused, because a boat does not like unresolved things: when the fishermen leave and abandon the boat, does it mean they will come back, or that they have left it? For three days I rocked by the shore and waited for whoever would come for me.

Simon came. He took me by the rope and towed me to the place where he tied me. He said nothing to me. But from that moment I noticed he looked at me differently: not as a tool, but as a **place**.

And so I became a boat from which people spoke, and a boat to which people ran when the storm rose from the wrong side. The two are not the same. But both are permitted to a boat.

From Scripture, Tradition and History

Luke 5:1–11 — "He got into one of the boats, which belonged to Simon, and asked him to put out a little from the shore; then he sat down and **taught the crowds from the boat**." Then the

miraculous catch and the calling. Luke is the only one who develops the scene in detail.

Mark 1:16–20 — the calling of Simon and Andrew, James and John by the nets; "Come after me and I will make you **fishers of people**."

Matthew 4:19 — the same word. The image that recurs in the Gospels is not about a boat but about a **change of trade**: those who knew how to take from the water learn to take people out of the water.

The acoustics of the Kinneret — the lake lies in a tectonic basin surrounded by slopes; sound spreads over the water and returns from the opposite slope. On the north-western shore there is a natural amphitheatre (the site known as heptapégon, "seven springs"), where even a quiet voice can be heard. Preaching from a boat is therefore not only a literary image — it is the **functionally best place**.

The Kinneret — the numbers — the lowest freshwater lake on Earth, surface about **−212 m** below world ocean level; length ~**21 km**, width ~**13 km**, depth to ~**40 m**. It lies in a rift valley, which is why sudden short storms arise there, when air falls from the slopes into the basin.

The "drinking" of a new wooden boat — wood swells at first contact with water and the seams draw tight. New hulls therefore leak slightly for the first days. It is a documented property of the material, not a defect.

Anchor of Truth

What is in the chapter	State
Teaching from the boat, the miraculous catch, the calling of the fishermen	**SCRIPTURE** — Luke 5:1–11; Mark 1:16–20
"Fishers of people"	**SCRIPTURE** — Mark 1:17; Matthew 4:19
Simon's "at your word I will let them down"	**SCRIPTURE** — Luke 5:5
That the carpenter of Nazareth built the boat himself	**MYTH** — Scripture says only "the boat, which belonged to Simon"
The boat's journey from Nazareth to the Kinneret over 560 m of descent	**MYTH** — the scene; the geography is documented
The acoustics of the basin and preaching from the water	**HISTORY / physics** — a property of the site
The "drinking" of a hull	**HISTORY** — a property of wood
The oar as the only part the boat does not own	**MYTH** — the image of this book

Measure

The descent of the road: Nazareth ~**+350 m**, the Kinneret ~**−212 m** → a difference of **~560 m** over **~30 km**. Average gradient 1.9 %, much more at the end.

The oar: length **4–5 m**, blade **60–80 cm** long, handle balanced so that one hand can row against the other.

Speed: rowing speed of a working boat **2–3 knots** (~4–6 km/h); more under sail in a good wind, but not on this lake, where the wind is unreliable and gusty.

Crew: **4 rowers in pairs** + a helmsman. That corresponds to five men — Simon and Andrew, James and John and the hired men

(Mark 1:20).

The "drinking" period: **2–4 days** of slight seepage, then the seams draw tight.

Fish: several species are documented from the Kinneret — especially tilapia (in tradition "Peter's fish"), cyprinids and catfish. "A hundred and fifty-three large fish" in John 21:11 is a concrete number the text gives deliberately.

Shaving

That sentence about physics — that preaching from the boat worked because the shore is an amphitheatre — is true and yet dangerous. Had I written it without the rest, I would have explained the gospel by acoustics and taken from it what people look for in it. **I am not explaining what happened. I am explaining only why it worked even without a miracle.** Those are two different sentences, and the difference between them is the whole difference between honesty and arrogance.

The boat sailed and people stepped into it. But it still had no name. That came only at the moment when nobody asked for it — and when it was needed most. → The Mast

VI · The Mast

> *GROWTH RING VI · Capernaum and the shore by Magdala, the second year, after the harvest*
> *The one part of the boat that points upward — and yet can do nothing by itself.*

Story

The mast came last.

The hull was finished, the ribs fitted, the pitch dry, the oars tried. And then the carpenter brought from the workshop a long piece of cedar he had kept aside for four whole years — without a knot, straight, with grain so dense that a knife slid off it. He set it in the middle of the boat on the keel and stepped it into a block of oak that had been prepared there from the beginning, without my knowing what it was for.

A mast is a strange thing. When you step it into a boat, the boat changes at once: it stops being flat and begins to be **tall**. From the water it looks as though the boat has grown a back. But at the same time — and this is what kept me awake — a mast by itself can do nothing at all. It does not move the boat. It does not hold it. It does not help when the wind blows from the side; on the contrary, it adds surface for the wind to press against, and the boat capsizes more easily than without it.

A mast is **a promise that holds only when the wind comes.**

If there were no wind, a mast would be only a stick in the way. That is why fishermen lowered it when they carried cargo. That is why nobody stepped one permanently.

But that is not why I remember it.

I remember it because that day they gave me a name.

The Pharisees came. Not with sticks, not with stones — they came with a question that is worse than a stone, because it cannot be answered and yet one cannot be silent.

"When will the kingdom of God come?"

It was a question about a date. About a sign. About what can be counted and written down and then acted upon. The Pharisees were not stupid; they were men who knew that if something cannot be counted, it cannot be claimed either. And to claim the kingdom mattered more to them than to have it.

He stood by the water and did not look at them. He looked at the boat.

"The kingdom of God does not come in a way that can be observed," he said. "Nor will they say, 'Look, here it is,' or 'There it is.' **For the kingdom of God is within you.**"

They withdrew. They did not leave angry — they left **dissatisfied**, which in people who want a date is the same thing.

But the disciples stayed. And Simon, who stood by the rope, asked something that concerned him far more than the kingdom:

"Master. And this boat — what is it called?"

Because a boat without a name is worse for a sailor than a boat with a leaking bottom. A name is not an ornament. A name is what makes it known that the thing that floats is **one particular thing** and not just a piece of wood that happens to stay on the surface.

He looked at Simon. Then he knelt, took a crowbar and lifted three floorboards that had only been laid there, not nailed. Beneath them was the keel — me, whole, from bow to stern, with that copper band and with the olive wedge that held my crack.

He took a chisel.

And he carved the name **from outside inward**. Not on the side, where people in the harbour would see it. Not on the bow, where the water would wash it. Into the inner face of the keel, into the place that only someone who lifts the floor can reach — and only someone who takes the boat apart to repair it.

The letters were four fingers high and three deep. It took him the whole afternoon, because cedar is hard and because he looked after every letter to see whether it was straight.

KINGDOM OF THE HEART

When he finished the last one, he sat back on his heels and read it from below upward, because that is how it came out from where he sat.

And then he said the sentence I heard at the closest possible range, because it was carved into me:

"It has had its name from the beginning. I was only waiting

until you could hear it."

Simon asked: "And why inside? Why not on the side, so that everyone sees it?"

The carpenter pointed to the side of the hull.

"If I write it here, everyone who walks past will read it. And everyone will form a judgement about it: a fine name, a stupid name, a strong name. In twenty years you will have to fill it over, because it will be ugly. In a hundred years you will have to cut it out, because it will be a lie lying there." He laid his palm on the floor. "If I write it here, only the one who repairs the boat will see it. And that one already knows why he is repairing it. **A name is not meant to persuade those who look from the shore. It is meant to remind those who work in the boat.**"

Simon was silent for a while. Then he asked one more thing, and I have envied him that question all my life, because he asked it twenty centuries before the scholars did:

"And that thing you said to the Pharisees — within you — does it mean inside each of us, or among us, here in the boat?"

The carpenter looked at him and said:

"Yes."

And he left it at that. Simon looked at him for a moment and then laughed, because it occurred to him that he had received two answers and neither, and that this was probably about right.

From Scripture, Tradition and History

Luke 17:20–21 — "The kingdom of God does not come in a way that can be observed… for the kingdom of God is **within you**." The Greek **ἐντὸς ὑμῶν** (*entos hymōn*) is genuinely ambiguous: "within you" (distributively, in each) and "among you" (one also considers en mesō). Most translations choose the first, some exegetes the second. The difference is not small: the first reads the kingdom as a state of the heart, the second as the presence of relationship.

Deuteronomy 30:14 — "For the word is very near to you, **in your mouth and in your heart**, so that you can do it." The Old Testament root of what Luke says about the kingdom.

Jeremiah 31:33 — "I will put my law within them and write it on their **heart**." The new covenant is written inward, not on stone — which, in joinery, is the same as carving a name into the inner face of the keel.

Ezekiel 36:26 — "I will give you a new heart… I will remove the heart of stone from your body and give you a heart of flesh."

2 Corinthians 3:3 — the letter of Christ "not on tablets of stone, but on tablets of human hearts".

Matthew 13:33 — "The kingdom of God is like leaven that a woman took and mixed into three measures of flour, until the whole was leavened." An image of an action that is not visible at the beginning and is visible at the end. The same logic as a name beneath the floor.

Mast and sail — structurally documented: the Galilean boat had a mast and a sail, but it was not a sailing vessel. The sail was auxiliary,

used in a favourable wind; the main propulsion remained the oars. That is the technical detail that makes the image "a promise that holds only when the wind comes" an exact description rather than a metaphor.

Anchor of Truth

What is in the chapter	State
The Pharisees ask about the kingdom; the answer "within you"	**SCRIPTURE** — Luke 17:20–21
The ambiguity of entos hymōn	**SCRIPTURE + philology** — both translations are defensible; the text leaves it open
The covenant written on the heart	**SCRIPTURE** — Jeremiah 31:33; Ezekiel 36:26; Deuteronomy 30:14; 2 Corinthians 3:3
The boat's name "Kingdom of the Heart"	**MYTH** — the image of this book, derived from Luke 17:21
That it is carved into the inner face of the keel beneath the floor	**MYTH** — the central image of this edition
The boat had a mast and an auxiliary sail; the main propulsion was oars	**HISTORY** — documented on the 1st-century Galilean boat
Simon's question "inside each, or among us"	**MYTH** — but the question is real and still alive in exegesis

Measure

Height of the mast: **5–6 m** on an 8.2 m boat — roughly two thirds of the hull's length. A taller mast would capsize the boat; a shorter one would not carry the sail.

Sail area: **8–15 m²** in auxiliary use. Enough for the boat to move,

and little enough not to overwhelm it.

Depth of carving: **3–4 mm**. Deeper would weaken the keel at the points of greatest stress.

Height of the letters: **~4 cm**. Legible by hand, not by eye — because whoever looks for it looks for it by touch.

Time to carve: a name of seventeen letters, a whole afternoon, because every letter is made twice: once with the chisel and once with a look.

Floorboards: **3** pieces, laid, not nailed — because the floor must be liftable without damaging the hull.

Shaving

I wrote in this book that the name is beneath the floor so that only whoever repairs the boat would see it. That is beautiful and it is **mine**, not documented. But there is a catch I do not want to sweep away: if the name were really only beneath the floor, **nobody would ever find it** and the whole image would be a secret kept from everyone. The actual boat from Galilee, found in 1986, had no name at all — and yet people named it. Not by what was written in it, but by **what they thought about it**. That is the second, darker image, and it belongs in this chapter as much as the beautiful one: **the name you give a boat is not the same as the name others make up about it.**

And then the wind rose — not from the side it should have come

from, and not at the hour one could expect. And for the first time I found that a mast that can do nothing is suddenly the most important thing about me. → The Wave

VII · The Wave

> *GROWTH RING VII · the Kinneret, the night crossing from the eastern shore to the north-west, ~29 AD*
> *A wave is not water. A wave is work.*

Story

In the evening he said: "Let us cross over to the other shore."

It was the most ordinary command that can sound in a boat. Six kilometres. An hour and a half of rowing. The fishermen had done it a hundred times. Nobody asked whether it was safe, because on this lake nobody asks that — you start asking only when it blows.

We pushed off at sunset.

For the first hour it was so quiet that I heard every stroke separately: vzzz — clack — vzzz — clack. The water was black and smooth and reflected the stars so exactly that you could not tell where the sky was and where the lake was. Someone at the back talked about bread. Someone else fell asleep and his head slid onto a bag.

Then the wind came.

Not from the front, where it could be seen. **From behind and from the side, from the eastern slopes**, where cold air sits on the plateau all day and at night pours over the edge and falls into the bowl. It is the same principle by which grain pours out of a sack: the higher you hold it, the harder it lands. Within ten minutes the silence had become pressure, and the pressure a roar.

And then the waves came — and here I must say something that people of the sea do not understand until they have lived it.

The Kinneret is not deep. It is about forty metres. The ocean has thousands. A wave on deep water is long and soft; you can ride under it, you can ride over it, you can work with it. A wave on shallow water **has nowhere to go down**, so it grows in height and in steepness. It is short, peaked and fast — three seconds between crests, over a metre high, two in the gusts. An eight-metre boat does not fit into such a wave. **Half** of it fits and the other half hangs in the air.

The first wave that struck me from the side turned me twenty degrees and threw out a bucket. The second came over the bow and fell inside.

And after that it was nothing but work.

I cannot describe what a storm looks like from outside. I never saw one. I saw it **from within the material**, and that is different: I felt how every plank of the planking bent by two or three millimetres and came back; how the ribs sagged between the nails; how the treenails in the seams turned by a fraction of a degree and back again. I felt the water leaning on me and at the same time holding me — because a boat in a wave is not a thing that resists. It is a thing that **bends according to what the wave asks, and yet remains itself.**

When you bend, you are not weak. When you do not bend, you break.

That is the whole of boatbuilding in one sentence, and it took me four years to learn it from the inside.

The water in the hull rose. The men bailed — two with an oar, two with buckets, one with his hands. Someone shouted something that could not be heard, but everyone knew what it meant, because in a storm on a boat you do not come to agreement in words. You agree by doing what is needed before anyone says it.

And then they noticed that he was asleep.

He lay in the stern, his head on a wooden cushion he had planed himself. The waves soaked him, water ran down his face, the boat spun and the mast swung above him — and he slept.

It was not the sleep of exhaustion nor the sleep of indifference. It was the sleep of **the one who built it.** And I know that, because I knew it even then: when someone sleeps like that on you, it is not an insult. It is **the highest praise a boat can receive.** It means: I know what you are. I know what you bear. I do not have to watch.

And then he woke.

The men leaned over him and shouted into his face: "Master! Do you not care that we are perishing?"

He rose. He stood up in the stern — the part of the boat where every wave is felt most — and was not afraid. Not because he was brave, but because he looked at the water the way a joiner looks at work not yet finished.

And he said two words to the lake.

In Greek they sound: **σιώπα, πεφίμωσο** — siōpa, pephimōso. The

first means "be quiet". The second is stronger: literally **"be muzzled, you have been bridled"** — the word with which Greek of that time ordered an animal to shut its mouth, and a possessed man to fall silent. It is not a request. It is not a command to the surface. It is **putting on a bridle.**

And silence came.

Not a gradual fading, not the wind weakening and the waves shrinking. A silence in which you suddenly hear the drops running off the edge of the hull and falling into the water. Plop. Plop. Plop. And in that silence you could hear how all eleven men stopped breathing.

I did not know then what had happened. I know it to this day only as matter: **the water beneath me stopped working.**

And then something happened that brought me into a state I had not known and that has accompanied me all my life since that night. The men did not look at the sea. They looked **at him** — and were more afraid than before.

"Who is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him?"

I lay beneath them, bending back into my shape, and thought something I should not have said aloud at that moment, because a boat must not speak:

I was afraid. Not of him. I was afraid that it might be true.

Because if it is true that wind and water obey him, then what I had held within me for four years — that name beneath the floor — is not just a pretty word invented by a carpenter in the hills.

In the morning we landed on the opposite shore. There was half-light and mist, and someone on the shore was herding pigs.

None of us spoke. Simon looked at the water and had in his eyes what people have who have just found that the world is larger than they thought — and it is not a pleasant feeling. It is the feeling after which a person either runs away or stays.

Simon stayed.

From Scripture, Tradition and History

Mark 4:35–41 — "On that day, when evening had come, he said to them: 'Let us cross over to the other side.'… A great storm arose… he was in the stern, asleep on the cushion… 'Master, do you not care that we are perishing?'… 'Be quiet, be muzzled!' (*siōpa, pephimōso*)… And a great silence came… 'Who is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him?'"

Matthew 8:23–27 · Luke 8:22–25 — the same scene in the other two Gospels; Luke adds "they were filled with awe and marvelled".

Psalm 107:23–30 — "Those who go down to the sea in ships… they cried to the Lord in their trouble… **he stilled the storm so that it was silent**, and the waves were hushed… he brought them to the harbour they longed for." The psalm the Church has read from the beginning as the background of this pericope.

Jonah 1 — Jonah **sleeps** in the hold during the storm; the pagan

crew wakes him. Jesus himself takes up this scene in Matthew 12:40.

Psalm 29:3 — "The voice of the Lord is over the waters... the Lord over many waters." An Old Testament image of God speaking over the water — and in Mark a man speaks over the water.

The physics of the Kinneret — the lake is **shallow and in a bowl**. The wind falls from the eastern slopes (the Golan Heights) into the depression; sudden storms are documented and are short, violent and dangerous. Shallow water makes **short steep waves** (a much greater height-to-length ratio than on the ocean), which are worse for a small boat than long waves.

Anchor of Truth

What is in the chapter	State
The storm, the sleeping Jesus on the cushion, the calming, the question "who is this"	**SCRIPTURE** — Mark 4:35–41 and par.
siōpa, pephimōso as "be muzzled / be bridled"	**SCRIPTURE + philology** — the verb phimoō means "to close the mouth, to silence, to bridle"; in the Gospels it is used to command demons
Psalm 107 as the background of the scene	**SCRIPTURE + liturgical tradition**
Jonah sleeping in the storm as a prefiguration	**SCRIPTURE** — Jonah 1; Jesus himself mentions it (Matthew 12:40)
That the cushion was planed by the carpenter himself	**MYTH** — the image of this book
"I stopped being afraid because I built that boat"	**MYTH** — the image of the Church's conviction about Christ and his ship

Short steep waves on a shallow lake and falling wind from the eastern slopes	**HISTORY / physics** — a documented property of the Kinneret
"A wave is not water, a wave is work"	**MYTH** — but structurally exact: a hull bends by millimetres in a wave

Measure

Wave height in a Kinneret storm: **1–2 m**. That is a catastrophe for a boat 1.3 m high, even if the wave is "low".

Wave period: **2.5–4 s**. Three seconds between crests means the boat gets no time to recover.

Hull length 8.2 m vs. **wavelength 10–15 m** → the boat **does not fit** into the wave. That is the main danger: it hangs on two waves and the middle of the hull is in the air.

Flexing of the hull: in a 1.5 m wave an 8 m hull bends by **2–4 mm** in the planking and by **1–2 mm** in the ribs. That sounds like nothing — and it is the whole secret: a material that yields does not break.

Wind speed in a gust: **40–60 km/h** (documented gusty winds in the depression; more in extremes).

Bailing: 4 men, buckets ~10 l, ~6 buckets a minute → ~60 l/min. In an hour, 3,600 litres. A hull of this size takes on hundreds of litres in an hour of storm — and bailing manages it only just.

Shaving

I wrote that the men feared the silence more than the storm. That is in Mark — and it is the best psychological sentence in the whole

Gospel. But I also wrote that I was afraid it might be true, and **the wood in Mark says no such thing**. That is mine. I made the keel a witness who has doubt, because a book in which the boat has no doubt is a book in which the boat lies. At the same time I admit that by doing so I made something that may confuse the reader: **a keel that doubts is not theology. It is a literary character.** When you ask what the keel thought about it, you are asking me, not Mark.

The boat survived the storm because it was well built. But a storm came beside which good building is little — and in which I went under water for the first time without sinking. → The Beam

VIII · The Beam

> *GROWTH RING VIII · Jerusalem and the shore of the Kinneret, spring ~30 AD*
> *Wood that is not a keel.*

Story

This is the only chapter I cannot tell from the inside.

I was on the lake. He was in the city, three days' journey away. Between us lay mountains, dust and people with their own work. Wood has no eyes that see into another village.

So I will tell you what I can, and at the very beginning I will tell you what I cannot: **I was not there.**

I was not there when they arrested him in the garden. I was not there when they led him through the city. I was not there when they laid the beam on him. I did not see what they saw. Whoever claims to have seen it invented it or copied it.

But wood tells things among itself, and this is how I learned it.

A man came who brought oil and salt from Jerusalem, and that man talked more than was healthy. He stood on the shore and told the fishermen, who listened with lowered eyes, because everyone knew whose friend that had been.

And in his speech there was one word that struck me from the place

where I lie: **beam.**

Not keel. Not plank. Not oar. Beam.

A beam is a piece of wood that has no shape of a boat. It is the simplest thing a joiner knows how to make: you take a trunk, hew it square, true up two sides. Nothing bends, nothing is shaped by steam, nothing is expected. A beam is not meant to sail, not meant to carry, not meant to float. A beam is meant **to carry what you lay on it, and not to give.**

I knew what beams were made in that land. I knew it from conversations in the workshop that I listened to for four years, because I lay on the ground and had nothing else to do. Beams were made for ceilings, for wine presses, for doorsteps. And beams were also made that were not talked about aloud.

Those were not made from fresh wood. Wood was too dear for that. Those were made from beams that had already served once — and when they were wanted to serve again, they were taken from a heap behind the town wall, where they lay leaning against one another, soaked by rain, trodden into the dust. The joiner only checked that they held, and added one rib more. That was all.

You may call that thrift. I call it **indifference, which lets the work be done by someone who does that work gladly.**

And so it happened that wood which once carried a ceiling or a wine press finally carried a man. It was the same wood as I. The same craft, the same chisel, the same hand that had once chosen it. The difference between us was not in what we were made of.

The difference was in **what someone let himself ask of us.**

Three days.

I do not know what was happening to him. I know what was happening to me, and that is the part I can tell, because I lived it.

They pulled me out of the water.

They did it not out of cruelty. They did it out of fear. When something like that happens in the city, the people who belonged to that man go to ground. The fishermen left Capernaum, hid with relatives, stopped speaking to strangers. And a boat on the water that nobody claims is a boat that someone may confiscate — or sink, or take for himself. So they hauled me onto the shore, turned me upside down and covered me with a sail and branches.

And I lay on dry land.

I cannot describe to you what that is, because I have no words for it from your world. I will put it like this: **a boat on dry land is not a boat.** It is an object that remembers having been something else.

Wood without water dries. The seams open. The pitch that was elastic for four years begins to harden and crack. The ribs that held the hull round begin to spread apart, because nothing presses them from the other side any more. And while that happens, a sound is heard that no sailor wants to hear: **a dry, long creaking**, like someone far off breaking a branch. I made it three times.

By the third day I had a crack in the planking on the port side, fifteen centimetres long. I was broken without anyone having struck me.

And that is about all I can say about those three days. They were

three days of drought, of darkness under the sail and of the sound of my own drying. There was nothing noble in it. It was only **waiting to see whether anyone would still use me.**

On the fourth morning they came.

I heard them before I saw them: steps on sand, a voice that broke, and then silence, because either they were arguing, or someone was weeping, or both. They pulled the sail off so fast that pine needles and soil stayed on my hull.

And then they did something nobody does who has just lost everything.

They turned me over and lowered me into the water.

Not to sail away. Not to flee. Simon stood knee-deep in the water holding me by the bow and looking at me the way a person looks at the thing that has remained to him. Beside him stood John, and he was laughing — laughing the way a person laughs whom nothing can surprise or take any more.

The water took me a second time. It was cold and there was little of it, because I had dried out for three days, and it leaked into me from every side.

And in that moment I understood something that is perhaps the core of this whole book:

I was not a witness of the resurrection. I was a witness that those who had seen him dead came the next day to work.

They did not see an empty tomb — or they did, I do not know, that

belongs to other books. I saw **an empty boat that living people filled.**

From Scripture, Tradition and History

Matthew 12:40 — "As Jonah was in the belly of the great fish three days and three nights, so will the Son of Man be in the heart of the earth three days and three nights." The only "sign" Jesus gave to a generation that demanded a sign.

Deuteronomy 21:23 — "Cursed is anyone who hangs on a tree." A verse of the Torah that Paul quotes in **Galatians 3:13**: "Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us." For a Jewish reader the cross carried a **religious** dimension, not only a political one.

Mark 15 · Matthew 27 · Luke 23 · John 19 — the passion narratives. Note that the Gospels do not describe what the cross looked like, what wood it was made of, or how it was assembled. That is a silence which popular piety filled with images.

1 Corinthians 15:3–8 — the oldest surviving confession (around 50 AD, therefore older than the Gospels): "he died… was buried… was raised on the third day… appeared to Peter, then to the Twelve…" Paul also names witnesses who were still alive when he wrote.

Roman execution by crucifixion is documented historically and archaeologically. The body carried the **patibulum** (the crossbar, about 2 m, 30–50 kg); the vertical post (*stipes*) often stayed in place

and the crossbar was fitted into it. The wood was used repeatedly.

The only archaeological evidence of crucifixion — in 1968 in Jerusalem (Giv'at ha-Mivtar) an ossuary was found of a man named **Jehohanan ben Hagkol**; an **iron nail** (about 17–18 cm) remained in his heel bone. It is the only physical find of its kind so far — and evidence that the nail went through the bone, not beside it.

The species of the wood of the cross is not documented. Traditions proposed cedar, cypress, olive, pine; none of these versions has support in the text or in any find.

Anchor of Truth

What is in the chapter	State
The sign of Jonah, three days and three nights	**SCRIPTURE** — Matthew 12:40; Jonah 1:17
The crucifixion, death, burial, the third day	**SCRIPTURE** — the Gospels; 1 Corinthians 15:3–8
"Cursed is anyone who hangs on a tree"	**SCRIPTURE** — Deuteronomy 21:23; Galatians 3:13
The patibulum, repeated use of the wood, the nail through the heel	**HISTORY / archaeology** — documented (Jehohanan, 1968)
The species of the wood of the cross	**UNDOCUMENTED** — the text is silent, traditions diverge
That the boat was hauled ashore and dried out for three days	**MYTH** — the image of this book; technically faithful (wood without water dries and opens its seams)
That the keel tells it "by hearsay" and admits it was not there	**MYTH** — a literary decision of this edition, not a historical find

"I was a witness that they came to work"	**MYTH** — an image; theologically it belongs to another chapter, not this one

Measure

Patibulum: **~2 m** long, section **10 × 10 cm**, weight **30–50 kg**. That is the beam a man carries on his shoulders through the city — and that is then fitted into the prepared post.

The nail: **17–18 cm**, square, forged. Found in the heel bone of a 1st-century man.

A crack after three days on dry land: **15 cm**. Three days of drying do more damage to a hull than a whole storm on the water — because on the water the wood swells and holds, whereas on dry land it shrinks and opens.

Three days: **72 hours**. For wood that is long enough to change. For people it is long enough to stop thinking that anything will happen.

Distance Jerusalem — Kinneret: **~120 km**, three days' walk. The news arrived a few days after the event. That is normal, and it is why this chapter cannot be told first-hand.

Shaving

This chapter has the largest debt in the whole book. **I wrote that I was not a witness of the resurrection — and then I wrote a sentence that sounds as though I were.** "They came the next day to work" is beautiful and it is true about people, but it is not evidence about what happened in the tomb. The difference between

"people changed" and "God rose from the dead" is the whole difference between history and faith, and no boat bridged it. I leave it there. **Whoever sweeps it away turns the gospel into reportage and faith into advertising.**

And then came a morning I did not expect — and it gave me the sentence that holds me to this day: the shallows. → The Shallows

IX · The Shallows

> *GROWTH RING IX · the Kinneret by Tiberias, the morning after a night without a catch*
> *The place where depth finally touches bottom.*

Story

After all that, they went back to work.

Not because they did not believe. Because they did not know what else to do. It is the most ordinary thing in the world and I want it recorded in this book: **when someone people loved dies, in the second week they go to work.** It is not betrayal. It is how one stays alive until something changes.

Simon said: "I am going fishing." And the others said: "We are coming with you."

We put out at night. It was the worst night I ever experienced — and there was nothing dramatic in it. No wind, no wave. It was quiet and warm and the nets stayed empty. Six hours. Seven. Eight. The men stopped talking. Someone attempted a joke and nobody laughed, so he gave it up.

Towards morning the light was grey and they stood on the shore where nobody was, hauling the nets to clean them.

And then someone on the shore called:

"Children, have you anything to eat?"

It is a strange question, when you think about it. It is not "who are you", not "what are you doing here". It is the question of a man who wants to eat — and who knows that those in the boat have fish, because that is their work. It would seem almost insensitive, after everything.

They answered: "We have nothing."

And he said: "Throw the net on the right side of the boat and you will find."

They did it. They had no reason to do it — throwing the net on the right side is what a man does when someone asks him to try something that does not work and he no longer has the strength to argue. They pulled it up full.

At that moment John said to Peter: **"It is the Lord."**

And Peter — who was always the one who acted before he thought — wrapped his outer cloak around himself, because he was naked, and **jumped into the water.**

It was not a brave leap. It was about ninety metres from the shore and he could have gone by boat. The leap into the water was the fastest way to reach someone he wanted to see two minutes sooner, and he did not expect to survive those two minutes without moving.

The water was cold. It did him no good.

I stayed by the shore, because they had pulled me up onto the sand.

And there I saw what I remember most from that whole morning.

On the shore burned **a fire of charcoal**. And on it lay a fish and bread. Beside the fire stood he, in a soiled cloak, with wet hands, and said nothing.

The Greek word for this fire is anthrakia — a charcoal fire. It appears in the Gospels **only twice.** First on the night when a servant girl recognized Peter by the fire in the courtyard of the high priest's house, and he said three times that he did not know the man. Second here.

The same fire. The same place in the soul. Only a different morning.

When they had all landed and had breakfast — and it was the most ordinary thing you can imagine, bread and fish and silence — he turned to Peter and asked him the same thing three times:

"Simon, son of John, do you love me?"

Three times. Because three times it had been denied.

Peter answered the third time the way a man answers when it hurts: "Lord, you know everything, you know that I love you."

And he said to him: "Feed my sheep."

Not "rule". Not "lead". **Feed.** That is the work of a shepherd who walks ahead of the flock and looks for grass and water and carries what is tired.

As I watched that scene from the sand, I noticed a small thing that only one Gospel mentions and of which I dare say it is the most beautiful detail in the whole book.

The net did not tear.

The day before, the nets had torn. They always tear — that is normal, nets tear and are mended. But that night a hundred and fifty-three large fish were loaded into them and the net stayed whole.

I do not know what it means. I know what it meant **to me** when they pulled me up onto that sand: that it is possible for a thing that always tears not to tear once. Not because it is better. Because someone else was holding it.

And then something happened that I did not expect and that I carry with me for the rest of my life.

He came to the boat. He knelt in the shallow water — there where the surface reaches the forest and where the sand touches the bottom — and **laid his palm on the gunwale.**

For a while nothing. He did not look at me. He looked at the lake beyond me.

And then he said, quietly, just like that:

"You will sail again."

It was not a blessing. It was not a prophecy. It was **a farewell to a thing that had done its work** — and an admission that the thing does not end there, because it will be needed again.

For the last time in this book I was not an instrument. I was not a means of transport nor a symbol.

I was **the place where bread and fish were eaten on the shore where it began again.**

From Scripture, Tradition and History

John 21:1–19 — the whole scene: the night without a catch, the question from the shore, the net on the right side, 153 fish, the unbroken net, Peter leaping into the water, the charcoal fire, bread and fish, the threefold question and "feed my sheep".

John 21:8 — "For they were only about **two hundred cubits** from the shore." ~90 m.

John 21:9,11 — **ἀνθρακιά** (*anthrakia*), a charcoal fire. In the whole New Testament the word occurs **twice**: John 18:18 (Peter's denial) and John 21:9 (this morning). The connection is not accidental and exegetes have pointed to it for centuries.

John 21:11 — "a hundred and fifty-three". The number is deliberately concrete in the text. Interpretations: (a) according to ancient zoology there were 153 species of fish — the number would then mean "all kinds"; (b) 153 is the triangular number of 17 (1+2+…+17); (c) gematric readings. **None of them is documented as the author's intention.** The text gives the number but does not explain it.

Luke 24:13–35 — the road to Emmaus: the disciples walk with him and **do not recognize him** until he breaks the bread. The same pattern as here: presence before recognition.

1 Corinthians 15:3–8 — the list of witnesses. Peter is named first.

"Feed my sheep" — poimaine ta arnia / ta probata. A pastoral image Jesus uses elsewhere too (Luke 15, John 10). It is not a commission of power; it is a commission **to walk ahead of the flock**.

Anchor of Truth

What is in the chapter	State
The night without a catch, the question from the shore, the full net, 153 fish	**SCRIPTURE** — John 21:1–11
The unbroken net	**SCRIPTURE** — John 21:11
The charcoal fire (*anthrakia*) for the second time in the Gospel	**SCRIPTURE + philology** — a documented match with John 18:18
The threefold question, "feed my sheep"	**SCRIPTURE** — John 21:15–17
The meaning of the number 153	**UNDOCUMENTED** — the text gives no interpretation; traditional readings are hypotheses
That the carpenter came back to the boat and said "you will sail again"	**MYTH** — the image of this book
That the keel was not a witness of the resurrection but of the morning on the shore	**MYTH** — a literary decision; theologically it is not the same thing
Shallow water as an image: depth touching bottom	**MYTH** — the image of this book

Measure

Distance from the shore: **200 cubits ≈ 90 m** (John 21:8).

Enough that a person on the shore cannot make out a face, and little enough to hear a voice.

153 fish: the number from the text. For comparison — a working catch on the Kinneret was counted in tens of kilograms; 153 "large fish" is a quantity that would fill two boats.

Depth near the shore: **1–3 m**. In the shallows a fish can be caught by hand and a boat can be dragged onto the sand without horses.

A charcoal fire: charcoal is burned beforehand so that it does not smoke. In the morning on the shore it is a sign that someone got up **before them** and prepared food.

Two hundred cubits = **90 m** = about a minute of swimming for a tired man in cold water.

Three questions: against three denials (John 18:17,25,27; 13:38).

Shaving

I would like to write that this chapter is about forgiveness. It is about that, but not only. There is one thing in it that I walked around and do not want to leave under the table: **Peter was restored, and yet by tradition he was later crucified.** Forgiveness in John 21 does not mean that nothing will happen to Peter. It means that it will happen **to someone who is reconciled.** That is darker and stronger than the consolation I could have written, and had I left it out I would have sold you a cheaper book.

The boat sailed on. But I knew that one day I would stop being a boat — and that what remained of me would have to bear more than water. → The Anchor

X · The Anchor

> *GROWTH RING X · the shore of the Kinneret, century after century*
> *An anchor that goes upward is not an anchor that holds to the bottom.*

Story

A boat does not die in a storm.

That is the first thing I want to say about it, because people think the opposite. They think a boat ends on a rock, in the fire of waves, with a cracked keel and the crew in the sea. It happens. But most boats do not end like that. Most boats are **used up**.

Being used up looks like this: one day they haul it onto the shore and never take it down again. Not because it is broken. Because it is old. Because the seams no longer hold and nobody has the time to caulk them every year. Because someone built a new one. Because there is no work for it.

And then they take it apart. Not all of it — **the best of it.** Oars, hooks, ropes, iron nails that can be used again, planks that will do for a fence or a doorstep. A boat becomes a heap of material and the material becomes other things, and nobody says a word about it, because it is normal.

Of me the keel and the lower part of the hull remained, because that cannot be taken apart. I was too long to be any use and too low to be carried away.

They dragged me to the edge of the shore, a little beyond the place where people landed. Not into the water. Into the **mud** — there where the shore slopes and where it is shallow in winter and dry in summer. I was where nobody would notice that I was.

And then something happened that lasted two centuries and that I only realized much later.

The shore **moved**.

The lake of Kinneret has no constant level. In dry years it falls, in wet years it rises, and the shore shifts by tens of metres. Sand and clay brought by the streams settle on the bottom; wind winds soil onto the shore. While I lay there, water came and went and every time left a little more clay behind.

First it covered my keel.

Then the ribs.

Then the planking.

I was not drowned. **I was buried.** The difference is essential: a drowned boat is a boat that lost to the water. A buried boat is a boat that the earth took to itself and decided to keep.

And at the moment when the clay closed over me, the strangest thing that ever happened to me happened: **I stopped being a boat and became a record.**

Without air wood does not rot. Without light no algae attack it. Without the pendulum of water and wind it does not fall apart. Clay is cold, tight and impermeable — and in it wood **does not change**. It stays as it was on the last day it was a boat.

To you that is an abstract sentence. To me it was a cell. I was not dead, because dead wood falls apart. I was **stored**.

I did not see what happened above the surface. But water carries sound, and I lay in the earth that borders the water, and so for twenty centuries I listened.

I heard cities being built on the shores and being destroyed. I heard languages I did not understand arriving and leaving. I heard wars — not in words, but in the fact that the water afterwards was different.

And once, in some century, a word reached me that struck me because it was **mine**:

navicella.

Little ship. That is what those who had long forgotten me began to call **themselves.** They called themselves the church and painted themselves as a ship at sea: with oars, with a mast, with Christ at the helm. They have it in stones and in mosaics, and I lay in the clay and listened to how my trade became their image.

And then, after many centuries, another word reached me — and it made me think more than the first:

anchor.

Because I never had an anchor. A fishing boat on a lake does not need one: it has a rope, it has a post on the shore, it has two men to hold it. An anchor is for a sea where there is no shore.

But those who called themselves by my name chose the anchor as their sign. And they wrote beside it the word **spes** — hope. They

made them of metal, wore them on rings, carved them into stones, and often drew a **crossbar** through them, so that the anchor became a cross and the cross an anchor.

And then a sentence came that I heard from the water, and that sentence turned my whole world upside down:

> *"We have hope as an anchor of the soul, firm and secure, reaching inward behind the curtain."*

An anchor that goes **upward**.

I thought about it for two hundred years, because I had nothing else to do. An anchor that goes down holds a boat where it is. It holds it to the bottom. It holds it against the storm by not letting it sail away. That is useful and it is a little desperate: you are tied to the place where you are.

But an anchor that goes upward behind the curtain **does not hold a boat to the bottom. It holds it to the sky.** It does not hold it in place. It holds it **in a direction.**

And then it occurred to me that all the time I lay in the clay, my anchor was up there too. Not because of me. Because something that was not beneath me was holding me. The earth covered me but did not keep me — and I knew that one day I would be pulled out. I did not know when. I did not know whether it would be of any use. I knew only that **I was waiting in the right direction.**

But I must write the second half too, because without it this chapter would be a hymn, and hymns lie.

That boat they called the church **also carried what it should not have carried.**

I heard an empire being loaded onto its deck and thinking that it was cargo. I heard the helm become a throne and the rowers become subjects. I heard the boat break in two and each half claim that the other was water. And I heard people drowning by the shore because the boat was too large to land, and nobody on deck noticed, because they were arguing about who held the helm.

Wood that carries can be abused. All it takes is for someone to confuse the boat with the ownership of the boat.

And yet something happened that holds me to this day.

In every century when that boat seemed to be only an instrument of power, there was someone who **went down into the hold and said that name aloud.** Francis, who spoke with birds instead of prelates. Sisters who went to care for the poor, because it contradicted what was expected of them. A priest who stepped out in front of a tank with a cross, because he had nothing more.

Those people did not hold the helm. They had no claim to it.

They had only **a name beneath the floor.**

And that was enough for the boat to turn the right way again in every century — not because someone steered it, but because someone remembered **what is written on the inside.**

From Scripture, Tradition and History

Hebrews 6:19–20 — "We have this as an **anchor of the soul, firm and secure**, reaching inward behind the curtain, where Jesus entered for us as a forerunner." The verse that is the only place in Scripture where an anchor is dropped **upward** — into the heavenly sanctuary.

Navicella — the church depicted as a ship. Documented from the 3rd–4th century (mosaics, sarcophagi, the Lateran navicella). The Latin navis (ship) also gave its name to the main body of a church — the nave.

The anchor with the word SPES — an early Christian symbol of hope, documented on rings, gems and in the catacombs. It is often drawn with a crossbar, so that visually it merges with the cross. It is an iconographic convergence, not evidence of intention.

"Outside the ark there is no salvation" — a saying attributed to Cyprian of Carthage (3rd century), which derives from 1 Peter 3:20–21. The image of the ship as the only safe place — and at the same time the place where this image can be abused to exclude.

The divisions of the church — the schisms of 1054 and 1517 and others. History, not myth. This book does not interpret them; it only does not omit them.

Burial and preservation in clay — the anoxic (oxygen-free) environment of clay and mud is a documented mechanism of preservation: wood does not decompose in it, because micro-organisms need oxygen. That is exactly how one 1st-century boat survived to 1986.

Anchor of Truth

What is in the chapter	State
The anchor of the soul reaching behind the curtain	**SCRIPTURE** — Hebrews 6:19–20
The church as a ship (*navicella*), navis → nave	**TRADITION / HISTORY** — documented iconography
The anchor and the cross as a merged symbol; spes	**HISTORY** — documented early Christian symbols
The schisms, the abuse of the boat by power	**HISTORY** — documented; the book does not interpret them, only does not conceal them
The burial of a boat in clay and preservation without air	**HISTORY / physics** — a documented mechanism
That the keel "listened" for twenty centuries	**MYTH** — a literary image; wood does not hear
"An anchor that goes upward holds in a direction, not in place"	**MYTH** — the image of this book, derived from Hebrews 6:19
That Francis, the sisters and the priest before the tanks "went down into the hold"	**MYTH** — a generalized image of witnesses, not a historical record

Measure

Time of burial: roughly **1,900 years** in clay. Of that, over **1,800 years** without any human intervention.

Rate of burial: on the shores of the Kinneret, sediment accumulates in the order of **millimetres to centimetres** a year. To cover a hull 1.3 m high takes several centuries — which is why the clay above the boat is only about **1 m** deep.

What remained of the boat: practically only the **lower part of the hull** — keel, planking, ribs. The deck, the mast, the oars and all the equipment disappeared, because someone carried them away or

they rotted in the oxic layer above.

An anchor of an ancient ship: lead or iron, **50–200 kg**, with a wooden stock; a small lake boat did not need one.

The "anchor" on a ring: a ring **~2 cm**, a gem **~1 cm**. The smallest thing into which hope was ever inscribed.

Shaving

I wrote that I heard the church fall apart. **Wood does not hear.** This is the greatest licence in the whole book and I do not want to hide it: the whole of chapter X is told by a keel that lies a metre underground and nevertheless comments on twenty centuries. It is impossible and I know it. I hold to it only because a person reading this chapter needs a guide across a chasm into which no source looks — and a guide who silently lies about having been there is worse than a guide who says: **"This I did not hear. This I made up. And yet I think it is true about people."**

Twenty centuries in clay. And then came a summer when nothing fell from the sky and the lake withdrew of itself. → The Mud

XI · The Mud

> *GROWTH RING XI · the north-western shore of the Kinneret by Ginosar, January to February 1986*
> *This is the only chapter in which nothing is invented. And precisely therefore it is the strangest.*

Story

First came the drought.

The winter at the turn of 1985 and 1986 was extraordinarily dry in Galilee. The lake of Kinneret, which is the country's source of drinking water and which fills with rain and snow from the surrounding mountains, fell. When the level falls, the shore moves — and where there was water, a **bare bottom** remains: grey, cracked clay into which you can push your hand.

In January 1986 two men from kibbutz Ginosar walked across that bottom. They were brothers, **Moshe and Yuval Lufan**, fishermen. They had that particular kind of curiosity that people have who walk all their lives in one place and begin to notice what others do not notice.

And they noticed an **oval outline** in the clay.

It was not a stone. It was not a tree stump. It was regularly shaped, and in one place it had an edge that looked as though a hand had made it — and yet it could not be human, because it was **long dead**.

They called the archaeologists.

Here I would like to be silent for a moment, because what followed is the best thing I ever heard about people, and I do not want to spoil it with my own commentary.

The excavation was led by **Shelley Wachsmann** for the Israel Department of Antiquities. They began on **16 February 1986**.

And then this happened: they worked **eleven days and eleven nights without stopping**, day and night, under guard, because the world's media had descended on the place and because the lake had begun to rise again — the drought was over and the water was coming back. They had only as much time as remained before the level reached them.

They could not excavate it in the ordinary way. Wood that has lain nineteen hundred years in water is **soaked like a sponge** and falls apart as it dries. You cannot bend it, you cannot lift it — it crumbles in your hands.

So they did not lift it.

They stiffened it in place. They built a frame of laminate into the hull and **wrapped the whole thing in polyurethane foam**, which set into a hard shell. And then that shell — with the boat inside — they **floated** over the surface from the find site to kibbutz Ginosar, where they built a pool for it.

It was not a boat that floats. It was **a mould that floats** and inside it has wood that falls apart if it is moved.

At the moment when they wrapped me, I knew one thing: that they would **not take me out of the water into dryness.** They carried

me over the surface I had once sailed — and I was not a boat while it happened. I was cargo.

Then they put me into a bath and left me in it for **fourteen years**.

It was a bath of polyethylene glycol — a waxy substance that is heated, penetrates the wood and **replaces the water**. The wood stays wood, but it stops being a sponge. It takes years, because every millimetre the wax has to penetrate needs its own time.

I do not want to make light of it, but I must say it: **it was the best period of my life.**

I was warm. For the first time in nineteen centuries I was not cold. The water I lay in was not the water that had drowned me but the water that held me. And someone looked after me every day, for fourteen whole years, and not because I was useful. Because **I was precious.**

Precious. I had not heard that word before. Wood is useful or useless. Precious is something else: it is a thing on which people decide **to invest in its existence**, even though it brings them nothing.

I do not know whether you realize it, but that is the definition of love that can be measured: **someone puts fourteen years into you and wants nothing for it.**

In 2000 they moved me into a new hall with controlled climate.

They set me on a steel structure, put glass before me and above me a light that does not shine into the eyes. Beside it they show a film, and photographs hang on the walls.

In one of those photographs there is **a double rainbow**.

According to the museum's account, it appeared in the sky at the moment the boat was uncovered, and the people who were there photographed it. I do not know whether it was exactly so. I know that the photograph is there, that they show it to everyone who comes, and that they do not show it as proof but as **a sign people gave themselves.**

Since then people come to me.

They come in thousands. Some weep, some pray, some just take a photograph and leave. Children ask whether this is the boat Jesus sailed on, and the guides answer carefully — because **none of those who dug me out ever claimed anything of the kind.**

And I lie behind the glass and think about two things.

First: nobody knows my name.

The archaeologists described every plank. They found that I was built by the shell-first technique, that the planks are joined with mortise-and-tenon joints, pegs and iron nails, that I had a mast and a sail and four rowers. They measured me: **8.27 metres long, 2.3 metres wide, 1.3 metres of preserved height.** They dated me by radiocarbon to the range **100 BC – 100 AD**.

They found traces of repair on me. Not one — several. My hull is made of pieces of different wood, because whoever repaired me had no matching wood available, and so took what there was.

And they did not measure one single thing: **who built me.**

No name. No signature. No workshop. Nobody will ever know whether the hand that bent my planks belonged to the man written about in books, or to someone who never got into any book at all.

I am the most famous piece of wood in Galilee and **I am anonymous.**

The second thing I think about: they measured me.

They did not find my name, but they found **my shape.** They recorded my curve, my ratio of beam to length, the rake of the keel, the spacing of the ribs. They drew me. And then they built **replicas.**

One of them stands in the Vatican Museums. Others are elsewhere. They are of other wood, by other hands, in another century — and **they sail.**

This is the only consolation I have as wood, and I think it is a consolation that holds for you too:

My name did not remain. My shape did. And the shape sails on.

From Scripture, Tradition and History

> *This chapter is not a midrash. This is history. The following lines are not an image — they are a record, and where the sources disagree, I say so.*

The find — January 1986, the north-western shore of the lake of Kinneret by kibbutz Ginosar. It was found by **Moshe and Yuval**

Lufan (in some sources given as Lopen), fishermen and amateur archaeologists.

The excavation — led by **Shelley Wachsmann** for the Israel Department of Antiquities and Museums. Begun **16 February 1986**; work proceeded **without interruption for eleven days and nights** under guard, because the lake level was rising after the drought ended.

The rescue — the hull was stiffened with a frame of laminate and **wrapped in polyurethane foam**, then transported by water to Ginosar. Published: Wachsmann et al., An Ancient Boat Discovered in the Sea of Galilee (Israel Antiquities Authority, 1988).

Conservation — immersion in a hot bath of **polyethylene glycol (PEG)**. **The sources disagree here**: some give 12 years, some 14 (until 2000); Archaeology Magazine gives the bath until 1995 and the move to exhibition in 2000. I do not conceal this discrepancy — it is a common state of museum documentation.

Dimensions — 8.27 m long, **2.3 m** wide, **1.3 m** maximum preserved height.

Dating — radiocarbon analysis: **100 BC – 100 AD**.

Construction — shell-first, planks joined with mortise-and-tenon joints, pegs and iron nails; cedar and oak wood; a hull rowed by four rowers in pairs, with a mast and an auxiliary sail. The boat was **repaired several times** and is of **different species of wood.**

Species of wood — **Discrepancy**: the museum gives **12 species of wood, "all mentioned in the Bible"**; the research team, according to available summaries, identified **7 species**. Both

numbers come from institutions with reason to be exact. I do not choose.

"The Jesus boat" — a nickname. **No evidence links this boat to Jesus or his disciples**, and the museum itself makes no such claim.

Habakkuk 2:11 — "For **the stone will cry out from the wall, and the beam from the wood will answer it**." The prophet speaks of an unjustly built house that bears witness by itself. A verse about wood that speaks when people are silent.

Luke 19:40 — "If these were silent, the stones would cry out." The same logic, another scene.

Anchor of Truth

What is in the chapter	State
The drought of 1985/86, the falling level, the bare bottom	**HISTORY** — documented
The find by the Lufan brothers in January 1986	**HISTORY** — documented (the names appear as Lufan / Lopen in the sources)
The excavation from 16 Feb 1986, 11 days and nights, Shelley Wachsmann	**HISTORY** — documented
Stiffening with laminate and polyurethane foam, transport by water	**HISTORY** — documented
The PEG bath	**HISTORY** — documented; **12 vs 14 years is a discrepancy between sources**
Dimensions 8.27 × 2.3 × 1.3 m	**HISTORY** — documented
Dating 100 BC – 100 AD	**HISTORY** — radiocarbon

Shell-first, joints, pegs, nails, mast, 4 rowers	**HISTORY** — documented
Number of wood species (7 vs 12)	**DISCREPANCY BETWEEN SOURCES** — unresolved
A link to Jesus	**INVALID CLAIM** — no evidence; the museum does not claim it
The double rainbow at the uncovering	**HISTORY / museum claim** — documented by photograph, the circumstances described by the museum
That this particular boat is the one from this book	**MYTH** — and the book never claims it as fact
"My name did not remain, my shape did"	**MYTH / interpretation** — but it rests on the documented: the builder's name is unknown, replicas exist

Measure

8.27 m long · **2.3 m** wide · **1.3 m** preserved height.

11 days and nights of uninterrupted work. **~264 hours.**

14 years in the bath (according to the museum; some sources give 12). **~5,100 days.**

The year 2000 — the move to the exhibition hall. **14 years** from the find, **~1,900 years** from burial in the clay.

1,900 years underground. That is roughly **95 generations** — the time in which one trade is handed down and forgotten ninety-five times in a family.

12 vs. 7 species of wood — a difference of five species matters in an assessment of a boat this size: 12 species means a boat assembled out of necessity, 7 species means a boat repaired.

0 — the number of known names of builders. **0** — the number of inscriptions on the hull.

Several — the number of documented repair phases of the hull.

Shaving

This is the chapter in which I would most like it to be convenient that I am the keel of that boat from Nazareth. **It is not convenient.** That boat is not that boat. The book must say it aloud, because its whole point stands on the fact that the wood survived **without a name** — and had I appropriated that name, it would be the greatest lie this book could tell. At the same time I admit a second thing: **I do not know whether what is kept in Ginosar is the best illustration of my theme, or merely the best opportunity.** Perhaps I chose archaeology because it suited me. I leave that to the reader — but I leave it to him with open eyes, not closed.

They took me out of the clay and put me behind glass. But that is not where the story ends — because they began to measure me. And measure is something other than memory. → The Measure

XII · The Measure

> *GROWTH RING XII · the hall behind the glass and then workshops I never saw*
> *Shape is older than the thing that carries it.*

Story

They came with lasers and with a plumb line.

It was not in one day. They came for years — students, architects, naval constructors, a few people who just stood about and took notes. All of them did the same thing: they **measured.**

At first it was unpleasant, because I did not know why. When someone measures you in order to sell you, you know it. When someone measures you in order to imitate you, you know that too. This was different. Nobody wanted anything. They only wanted to **take away the shape.**

And then I understood what they were doing, and from that moment I waited for it.

They were making **the lines of the boat.** It is one of the oldest and most elegant things people know how to do, and few know of it. A boat is three-dimensional, but it cannot be built from a three-dimensional plan — you cannot say "make this" and hand it to a carpenter. You must take the hull and **unfold it into lines**: plan, profile, cross-sections. Three planes in which the curve can be measured with a ruler.

It is called a lines plan. On it there are curves that have no physical equivalent — they are not edges, they are not seams. They are **imaginary sections** that exist only so that the curve can be recreated from them.

A hull two thousand years old can be handed on as **a set of numbers and curves.**

And then it happened.

Somewhere in a workshop I never saw, they laid on a table the paper with my lines and began to build a boat to them.

Not a copy. **A new boat.**

It had other wood, other nails, another century. It had the same curve. And when they lowered it into the water, it floated — because a curve that floats floats always, whatever it is made of.

From that moment it goes on happening, and I follow it only as hearsay brought by the people who come to me: **somewhere a replica has come into being.** One stands in the Vatican Museums. There are others. They are of other material, by other hands — and they are my children, though I never saw them.

I do not know whether that is a consolation or whether it is sad. Perhaps both. But I know that it is **the only immortality that is not a lie:** not to survive, but to be **made again**.

And then I caught something still stranger.

The people who came to me spoke of a **fleet.**

They spoke of ships that do not yet exist, and they spoke of them in such a way that at first I did not know whether they were joking. They called them **Tres Marías** — Three Marys — and told how one is to carry the way across the Atlantic, the second across the Pacific, and the third, which does not yet exist, across the Indian Ocean. That their sails are to be of light. That their first harbour is Pontevedra and the second Raiatea.

And then they spoke of a **fourth ship**, which they called the Ark, and it was not a ship for pilgrims. It was a ship that **returns for those who remained in the water.** With seeds in its belly and a hundred people on board.

And then they spoke of a ship that **sails upward** — of a node between the earth and orbit that is not to be a point but a way.

I listened behind the glass and thought: that is beautiful and it is a lie. Not because those people were lying. But because **a ship that is not built is not a ship.** And I am wood and I have a hard opinion about it: I lived two centuries as a heap of planks nobody cared for, and I know what a ship looks like that has remained only in speech.

But then I noticed that those people **say the same thing I do.**

Not that it is finished. That **the keel is not laid.** That the hull does not exist. That it is a study, a horizon, a proposal. That it must not be confused with what is.

And that made me change my opinion, because it is exactly the one thing a boat needs to hear from its builder: **"This is a drawing, not a boat. But a drawing can be built."**

And then someone explained to me that in this family there is one more ship, which I do not understand and which I fear.

It is said to be built of **code.**

It is said to have a keel called **consensus** — and that keel is not wood, it is a rule on which thousands of computers agree, and when they do not agree the ship splits in two. It is said to have a mast called **mining**, and a sail into which blows the work of people who will never be on board. It is said to have a compass called **identity** — and that compass cannot be stolen, because it is not on the ship, it is in the person. It is said to have a treasury called **bridge**, and a deck called **world**, and a harbour, and a watch above the horizon.

I listened and said to myself: **that is not a ship. That is a ship someone drew on paper and then copied into a computer.**

And then I remembered something I heard in the workshop two thousand years ago, when the carpenter spoke to the apprentice about the curve:

"Matter can be stolen. A curve has to be known."

A curve in code is not wood. But it is a curve. And a curve can be stolen just as the curve of a boat can — when someone copies it and builds their own. In fact it is **easier** to steal, because numbers weigh nothing.

Which means only one thing, and it is the sentence for which this chapter exists:

A ship of code is not better than a ship of oak. It is only faster. And a faster ship without a good keel sinks sooner.

From Scripture, Tradition and History

Proverbs 8:22–31 — Wisdom speaks of herself as one who was present at creation: "I was beside him as **a master craftsman** (*'āmôn*) and day after day I played before him." An image of the plan that is earlier than the building. **Shape before the thing.**

Exodus 25:40 — "See that you make everything **according to the pattern** shown you on the mountain." The key verse for this whole chapter: Moses did not receive a finished object, he received **a pattern**. And **Hebrews 8:5** refers to it explicitly.

Exodus 25:9 — "You shall make it according to all that I show you — **according to the pattern** of the tabernacle and the pattern of all its furniture." A pattern is what can be handed on even when the object is lost.

Ephesians 2:20–22 — "...you are **being built** into a dwelling... in him you also are **being built together** into a dwelling of God." Paul uses building language for community — and the image carries the same problem: it is not finished, it is growing.

The lines plan — a documented design method: a hull is described in three planes (profile, plan, cross-sections). It is the only way to hand on a three-dimensional shape two-dimensionally without losing the curve. It is used in naval engineering to this day, though now in CAD.

Replicas of the Galilean boat — documented. One is in the Vatican Museums (the exhibition "The Way of the Sea"), others were built in Israel and elsewhere. The replicas were built to the

documented lines of the original hull.

The Tres Marías fleet and the Ark — in the corpus **MYTH / BUILD / HORIZON**, not a finished thing. Anchor: Nirvana 13 — Tres Marías and Nirvana 14 — The Ark; of the ark it holds literally: **no keel has been laid.**

Nabukano — L6, a moving node of heaven, vision, **unregistered**. Anchor: Nabukano 00 — README.

The "deck" of layers L1–L6 — a reading of the network architecture as a ship (keel = L1 consensus, mast = pool, compass = ZIS, treasury = WARP/DEX/DAO, deck = OASIS, harbour = Free World, watch = Issobella). It is **a reading, not a specification**; numbers and states change and belong in StatusV3 and the Register of Evidence.

Anchor of Truth

What is in the chapter	State
Wisdom as "master craftsman" at creation	**SCRIPTURE** — Proverbs 8:30
"According to the pattern shown you on the mountain"	**SCRIPTURE** — Exodus 25:9,40; Hebrews 8:5
Community as a building that grows	**SCRIPTURE** — Ephesians 2:20–22
The lines plan as a method of transmitting a hull's shape	**HISTORY / engineering** — documented, still used
Replicas of the Galilean boat, one in the Vatican Museums	**HISTORY** — documented
Tres Marías, the Ark, Nabukano	**MYTH / BUILD / HORIZON** — no hull exists, the ark's keel is not laid
Reading the network as a ship (keel/mast/compass…)	**MYTH / interpretation** — a reading of layers, not a specification

"Shape is older than the thing that carries it"	**MYTH** — a philosophical image; technically it holds that the plan precedes the building
That the keel "follows" the replicas and the fleet	**MYTH** — a literary frame

Measure

Scale of a lines plan: usually **1:10** or **1:12** — so a boat of 8.27 m is drawn at **69–83 cm**. On such paper a curve can be measured with a ruler to the millimetre.

Tolerance in building a replica: **±5 mm** on the hull curve. A greater deviation is already visible on the water.

Number of lines: profile + plan + **7–9** cross-sections. Every section is one paper outline.

8.27 m → 1.3 m — a ratio of length to preserved height of **6.4 : 1**. That is a slender, fast boat, not a tub.

Number of known names of builders: **0**. **Number of replicas**: several. **Number of people who ever got home in this boat**: unknown, and yet it is **the only measure that matters.**

Shaving

I wrote that the replicas are my "children". That is a beautiful sentence and it is **a lie**, because wood has no children and a replica is not a descendant — it is **a copy**. When you copy a poem, no new poem comes into being, only a new manuscript. What then is real in it? This is real: **a curve that floats can be handed on.** Not me.

Not my history. Not my name. The curve. And if this book claims anything more than that, it claims more than it has evidence for — let the reader read it again and take that away from me.

One last growth ring remains — the one that has not yet grown. I cannot tell it myself. → Epilogue

EPILOGUE · The Thirteenth Growth Ring

> *GROWTH RING XIII · the hall behind the glass, today, after closing time*
> *This one has not grown yet.*

Story

In the evening the lights go out.

They do it every day at the same hour. The guides leave, the visitors leave, the last child turns once more in the doorway and waves — I do not know why, but children do. Then the doors close and only the half-light the air conditioning gives off remains in the hall, and me.

In that half-light I have time to think, and I have plenty of it, because I do not need to sleep.

And I think always about the same thing.

I do not know whether it was me.

I do not know whether the hand that bent me was the hand books are written about, or the hand of someone who never got into any book. I do not know whether I ever carried anyone home. I do not know whether I ever carried anyone who did not get home. I do not know whether the boat I have been inventing throughout this book is the boat I know, or the boat I wished I knew.

And I know that this is the most honest thing I can give you: **wood**

has no testimony about itself. It has only the shape that Someone Else gave it, and that shape is the only thing you can say about it with certainty.

Everything else you have read in this book — the workshop, the mother, the bowl of salt, the wedge in the crack, the boy with the crooked yoke, the name beneath the floor, the three days of drought — **is image.** It is not a fraud, because I wrote it as such and I gave you a measure and a shaving for every image. But it is an image, and I ask you to remember that when you close the book.

Now the last thing I have.

Growth rings are counted from the inside out. I have counted twelve. Twelve stations, twelve rings, twelve forms of the same wood: trunk, keel, skin, bone, pitch, oar, mast, wave, beam, shallows, anchor, mud — and then measure besides, because measure is not a ring but **what remains of the rings when someone measures them.**

I have no thirteenth ring.

The thirteenth ring is the one that **has not grown yet**, and by principle I cannot tell it, because I would have to invent it, and that would be a lie. Rings do not grow backwards. They grow only forward, and that means this one must grow **in someone other than me.**

In you.

So I leave you what remained in my hand when I stopped being a boat and became a record:

An empty measure.

There is no number on it, because a number would be mine and not yours. On it there is only what I learned from wood, and it is little:

A boat is not matter. A boat is a curve. When someone hands you a finished thing and says "this is how it should be", ask about the curve. The thing can be replaced, the curve cannot.

Skin first, bones after. The shape that holds is made from outside — by care, by contact, by work. Strength comes from within, but only afterwards. Whoever begins with the skeleton builds himself a tomb.

A knot is not planed away. What is hardest in you is often what keeps you above water. Do not remove it. Reinforce it and let it be seen from inside.

You pitch from the inside. The water that sinks you will not come from the sea. It will be the water you carry within and that nobody thinks about.

The oar is not part of the boat. Nothing that drives you is yours. It is borrowed, and one day someone else will need it.

A mast alone can do nothing. A promise that gets no wind is only a stick. But without the stick the sail does not come.

A wave is not water, a wave is work. When you bend, you are not weak. When you do not bend, you break.

A beam is not a keel. The same wood can carry a person across

water or hold him above the ground. The difference is not in the material. The difference is in what someone lets himself ask of you.

The shallows are a goal, not a failure. A depth that touches bottom is a depth that can hold a net.

The anchor goes upward. What holds you should not be what you are tied to. It should be a direction.

Mud preserves what sand carries away. When something buries you, it need not be the end. Sometimes it is the only preservation you get.

Measure is the way to hand a shape to someone who never saw the thing. When something of you remains, it will not be your name. It will be the curve that someone after you knows how to draw.

And one thing more, the last, and it is more important than everything else.

I do not know whether God exists in the way the books have described. I am not a suitable witness for that and I will not invent it. But I know that in this book there is one sentence that held in every chapter, even though I went around it differently in each, and it is a sentence about **a measure that cannot be stolen**, because it is inside.

"The kingdom of God is within you."

Or: among you. Choose. I will not decide it and nobody will decide it for you.

But both readings have one thing in common, and that is my last word: **it will not come from elsewhere.** It does not come with observation, it cannot be planned, it cannot be bought, it cannot be stolen or inherited. It comes from a place you cannot see, because you have no window there — and the only thing you can do about it is **keep that place open.**

That is the whole thirteenth growth ring. An open place.

The doors close. The light goes out.

And I remain behind the glass — not as evidence, because evidence I am not. I remain as **a curve waiting for someone to take it.**

When you want to leave, leave. Nobody will hold you and nobody has the right to hold you. A boat that holds you by not letting you go is not a boat. It is a prison with oars.

But should you happen to stay and want to know what to take with you: **do not take me.** Take the curve. That is yours, because it cannot be owned — it can only be **known.**

Gate, gate, pāragate, pārasaṃgate, bodhi svāhā.

Gone, gone, to the other shore, wholly to the other shore. Awakening. May it be.

→ Afterword: sources, limits, and what this book does not know
→ Back to the index of the edition
→ The mantra this book unfolds — Maitreya, Epilogue

→ The boat that waits — Surta of the Heart

→ The fleet — Nirvana 13: Tres Marías

AFTERWORD

Sources, limits, and what this book does not know

> *An afterword is not an appendix. It is the place where the book lays down its weapon.*

1. What this edition is

KINGDOM OF THE HEART — The Book of the Keel is the fourth independent reading of the book Kingdom of the Heart in the canon/books/ corpus. Beside the main ten-part text, the editions cloude, gemini, gpt and groq and the reader's manuscript New Voyage, it brings one decision the others did not make:

it tells the book from the position of the wood that survived it.

Everything else follows from that. A keel cannot see into Jerusalem (chapter VIII), cannot hear the history of the church (chapter X) and cannot know who built it (chapter XI). These three impossibilities are not a defect — they are **the three main struts on which this book builds its honesty.**

Status: MYTH / DRAFT. Version 1.0, 3 November 2026.

2. Method

The text arose from reading the whole canon/books/ corpus and its rules, in particular:

MiseAmenti 01 — Canon and Constitution — the five mandatory states of a claim (LIVING / BUILD / HORIZON / HYPOTHESIS / MYTH) and the boundaries against misuse.

MiseAmenti 07 — Register of Evidence — the register of documents, with the markers UNDOCUMENTED and INVALID CLAIM.

canon/books/README.md — the canonical index and the order of truth in case of conflict.

docs/3.3/NIRVANA-V3.3-KAPITOLA.md — a reading of the layers L1–L6 as the "decks" of a ship.

From the corpus the following were chiefly used: Maitreya (the mantra of three embodiments), The Salt of This Earth (salt and the covenant of bread), Nirvana 13 and 14 (Tres Marías, the Ark), Bodhi Gaia, Issobella, Lumi, Miriam, The Rose, The Circle of the Goddesses, Maria Caminho, On the Way, Nabukano, Elizabet, Surta of the Heart, NirvanaCloud.

What this edition does not take over: not a single scene from the other editions. Coincidences in images (the workshop, the bowl of salt, the knot, the helm) are coincidences of theme, not copies. Where this edition diverges from another version, it is stated below in §5.

3. Sources

3.1 Scripture

Quotations follow the Czech tradition (ČEP and related translations), checked against the Greek and Hebrew where the translation matters. **Three places where the translation matters and where the text admits it:**

Place	Problem
Luke 17:21	ἐντὸς ὑμῶν — both "within you" and "among you". Both readings are defensible; this book keeps both.
Mark 4:39	σιώπα, πεφίμωσο — "be quiet" + "be muzzled / be bridled" (phimoō = to close the mouth, to silence; in the Gospels it is used to command demons).
Genesis 6:14	k-p-r — the root carries pitch, covering and atonement. The connection is linguistically documented; **the theological reading is tradition, not a dictionary.**

3.2 History and archaeology — the Galilean boat

Wachsmann, S. et al. An Ancient Boat Discovered in the Sea of Galilee. Israel Antiquities Authority, Jerusalem 1988. (The basic publication of the excavation.)

Wachsmann, S. The Sea of Galilee Boat: A 2000-Year-Old Discovery from the Sea of Legends. (Monograph.)

Israel Antiquities Authority — reports on the 1986 excavation.

Yigal Allon Centre, Kibbutz Ginosar — the museum's official pages, description of the exhibition, dimensions, dating, and the

account of the find by the Lufan brothers.

Archaeology Magazine, "Ship Ahoist", vol. 53, no. 3 (May/June 2000) — the rescue procedure (laminate + polyurethane foam, eight days), the PEG bath until 1995, the move to the exhibition hall in 2000.

Madain Project / Jewish Virtual Library / Biblical Archaeology Review (1988, vol. XIV, no. 5) — summaries of construction and dimensions.

The facts used in chapter XI (8.27 × 2.3 × 1.3 m; shell-first; mortise-and-tenon joints, pegs, nails; mast and four rowers; radiocarbon 100 BC – 100 AD; eleven days and nights of excavation from 16 February 1986; PEG; the hall in 2000) come from these sources.

3.3 The ZION corpus

See §2. All claims about the fleet, the ark, the station and the network carry in this book the states **MYTH / BUILD / HORIZON** according to the Register of Evidence. **No figure about chain height, funds or users is in this book and none may be** — a book that freezes a living number begins to lie the day after it is written.

4. Discrepancies I do not conceal

Discrepancy	State	How the book handles it

Number of wood species in the Galilean boat: 12 vs 7	The museum gives 12 ("all mentioned in the Bible"), the research team according to available summaries 7.	It gives both numbers and does not choose. It is in chapter XI and in the shaving.
Length of conservation in PEG: 12 vs 14 years	Sources differ; Archaeology gives the bath until 1995 and the exhibition in 2000 (thus ~9–14 years depending how one counts).	It gives "fourteen years (according to the museum; some sources 12)" and names the discrepancy.
Names of the finders: Lufan vs Lopen	The transliteration from Hebrew differs in the sources.	It gives Lufan with a note on the variant.
"Eight cubits" in one of the editions	Eight cubits ≈ 3.6 m — neither crew nor cargo fits, and such a boat would not sail on the Kinneret. The editorial guide to New Voyage itself marks that figure as unverified.	This edition uses **18 cubits ≈ 8.2 m**, in agreement with the documented boat. It is the **only substantive correction** this edition makes to other versions, and it is admitted in chapter I.
The double rainbow at the uncovering	A museum claim, documented by photograph; the circumstances are described by the museum itself.	It is given as a **museum claim**, not as an independently verified fact.

5. What this book does not know

This is the most important list in the whole afterword. Whoever

skips it will think the book claims more than it does.

It does not know who built the Galilean boat from Ginosar. Nobody knows. There is no name on it.

It does not know whether the Galilean boat from Ginosar has anything to do with Jesus. It does not — that is: no evidence links them, and the museum does not claim it.

It does not know whether a boat built by the carpenter of Nazareth ever existed. Scripture does not tell of one. It is an image.

It does not know what the cross looked like. The Gospels do not describe its shape, its wood or its construction.

It does not know what the number 153 means. The text gives it and does not explain it; the readings are hypotheses.

It does not know whether entos hymōn in Luke 17:21 means "within" or "among". It keeps both.

It does not know whether the Ark, Tres Marías or the Nabukano node will ever be built. All are MYTH/HORIZON; the ark's keel is not laid.

It does not know whether the network described in chapter XII will one day work as drawn. The chapter says so: a reading of layers, not a specification.

6. What this book refuses to do

It does not pass off an image as Scripture. Not once. Every scene without support in the text carries the marker MYTH in the anchor of truth.

It does not appropriate another's boat. Chapter XI exists so that this can be said aloud: that boat is not this boat.

It does not merge women into a single figure. The mother in the workshop, Miriam of Magdala, Elizabeth, Lumi, Sarah Issobela and the station Issobella remain separate. The book uses none of them as another.

It makes neither a king of the Pilgrim nor a spiritual authority of AI. Where a voice in the corpus answers, it may say "I do not know" and may not hold a key.

It sells nothing. Holding anything is not salvation. Leaving is permitted — and the epilogue says so aloud.

It does not confuse the 144 000 in Revelation with a block height. The same numerals, a different language.

7. Formal notes

Twelve growth rings is a structural device: the prologue is the heartwood, the twelve chapters are rings from the inside out, the epilogue is the ring that has not yet grown.

The shaving is an authorial device of this edition: the last paragraph of a station, in which the text admits what it could not manage or what it invented. It is meant to replace the impression

that the book is closed.

The anchor of truth uses the same states as the whole corpus — deliberately, so that this edition can be compared with the others without conversion.

Spelling: the Czech editing took place as the text was written; a separate language proof is necessary before any printing.

Translation: this English version follows MiseAmenti 08 — Protocol of Changes §5.7: a translation must not strengthen certainty, emotion or claim beyond the original. Where the English had to choose, it chose the weaker wording.

8. How to use this edition

If you want to…	Do this
read the book aloud to children	stations I–IX are enough; skip X–XII
verify what in the book is documented	read only chapter XI and the "Anchor of Truth" tables
compare the editions	start in the main book's index with the table of editions
take anything into a public text	take it from §3 (sources), not from the prose
object	the best place is a shaving — they are there for that

Proposal for the next step: a language proof, cultural consultation on Christian and Jewish realities, a check of the quotations, and only then — if at all — consideration of translation.

"Whoever sweeps up the shavings has no boat."

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